



KT MORRISON

summer swap 4

ARLO AND LILY
AND MR. GRAVES



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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

SUMMER SWAP 4

A Hotwife Swinger Novella

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CHAPTER 1

Cody had encouraged him to go along on a boat ride to the island, that they had a secret mission together. When Byron asked him what the secret mission was, Cody said it was classified.

And, yeah, there was something cool about shooting to shore in a ballsy speedboat with a dude who was a special forces guy, selected for some top secret mission. But, holy shit, he couldn't have anticipated what the secret mission was.

They'd boated into Great Cinnamon Bay, docked there, strolled up through the private grounds of a large wildlife resort, stopped at this big brick courtyard where there was a café like a miniature stone fort, right smack dab in the rainforest, under these towering palms and bright-colored birds looking north out over the Caribbean, somewhere toward Tobago.

All this with the guy his wife had a sexual crush on. The guy who'd rocked her world with his big, hard dick, put on a cowboy hat and role-played with her and sent her into leg-shaking orgasms. All while Byron had watched.

Fucking wild.

He and Cody sat and shot the shit over a couple iced Americanos, talking about anything besides Cheyenne and the dirty stuff they'd done together.

Then this silver Mercedes SUV pulls up, and Cody turns to it and says, “Looks like our guest has arrived.”

Seeing the Mercedes, and knowing Cody, Byron wondered for a few seconds while the SUV idled and whoever was inside got themselves together enough to exit the vehicle, if it was a celebrity. Like maybe Cody was rich and connected enough to have some singer, like Carla’s favorite singer, show up and do a few songs on the yacht, like a private show or something. Hell, maybe even a famous standup comedian or a big-time Vegas magician. And his faithful friend, his poisonous mind, whispered in his ear saying, “I bet he brought *Cheyenne’s* favorite singer.”

But Cody said, “She just landed in St. Thomas and had to ferry over. I had a driver bring her. She’s supposed to already be here with us, after all.”

And as Byron tried to decipher who the fuck Cody meant, the SUV door opens and this long, sexy, dark-tanned leg steps out, pearl-painted toes in a pair of expensive shoes, and right away it hit him.

Oh, shit. It was Paloma.

* * *

Now he and Cody and Paloma and Paloma’s luggage were on the speedboat and jetting back to the yacht and it was the first chance he’d got to send a warning to Sully.

He had a distinct feeling that maybe something happened last night in the “swinging” department and that it involved Sully, Scarlet, and Philippe. Like maybe Scarlet had gone off with Philippe for her turn to step foot in the wild swinging jungle like Cheyenne had done. If that was the case he figured Sully might like a head’s up that Philippe’s former wife was on her way.

But first he texted his wife.

Byron: red alert, we're bringing Paloma to the yacht

While he was thinking how to phrase a message to Sully, Chey got back to him.

Cheyenne: Who is this?

Byron: stop fucking around

Cheyenne: Do I know you?

Byron: Come on Chey tell Scarlet

Cheyenne: ok

He shook his head at what a dead end that turned out to be. Didn't Chey realize why Scarlet was a no-show at breakfast and at lunch? Either Sully had murdered her last night or she couldn't walk after getting her privates pummeled by Philippe's horse cock. He texted Sully.

Byron: hey man, nbd but me and Cody are bringing Paloma back to the yacht

He didn't want to come out and say what he suspected in case Sully wanted to keep the whole swinging thing secret. If in fact anything had happened.

The sea breeze ruffled his hair when he looked up from his phone. The boat's motors were loud at this velocity and he was thankful for it. It saved him from conjuring small talk with Paloma. He had little in common with Philippe's former wife. She was Brazilian, spoke English as a third language, and came from a wholly different background, and had a much different lifestyle than him. Paloma intimidated him. She was beautiful and

sexy in a Sports Illustrated swimsuit issue kind of way. He sat at the back of the boat, waiting for a return text as a confirmation, watching Cody at the helm, shirt off, bronze back muscles squirming as he wheeled the boat over the skips of waves, his blonde hair fluttering like the Stars and Stripes. And between Byron and Cody, Paloma sat in a yellow sundress, bronze legs crossed, thick waves of chestnut hair tossing in the wind.

His phone chimed.

Sullivan: Sure sure. Thanks buddy.

Then he sent a Jennifer Lawrence gif of the actress nodding exactly how Sully intended the tone of his text: I don't believe you.

"Idiot," he said under his breath, the wind taking his words away. He tilted up his phone, watching the screen, getting Paloma in full frame, Cody ahead of her manning the controls. He snapped a picture and sent it to Sully.

* * *

Carla said, "I think she's in my tub."

"No, seriously," Sully said. He'd raced down to Philippe's suite and found the room empty, his wife gone, the room tidied and the bed made. He raced to his own suite and found it empty too. Scarlet was alive but missing, he figured, since her things had been moved to their room and a breakfast tray there too, a half cup of coffee and toast crumbs.

"Seriously, check the bathroom in my suite. Knock first."

A sudden jealous monster jumped out at him, but then it was quashed fast. He'd felt the flames of green jealous fire for a second thinking someone might be in the tub with her, but shit, Philippe was in the lounge where

they'd been playing pool, Byron was on the boat and had sent a live photo of Paloma, and Cody was in it, piloting the boat. Arlo was upstairs cooking.

"Yeah, yeah," he said, more to say but no time, thanking Carla and shooting up the stairs from the kitchen and down the hall to Cody and Carla's suite. He skidded to a stop outside and knocked on the door. Waited. No answer. Knocked again.

Still no answer.

So he tried the handle and levered open the door. It was unlocked. He eased the door open and poked his head into the room. The room where he and Scarlet had watched Cody fuck Cheyenne while Byron watched.

The sliding glass door was open on the far side, bright day beyond the room's balcony, and Scarlet was laughing in the bathroom.

Why was she laughing?

She was in there with someone. That fiery ember in his body went bright orange with the jealous breeze and burst into bright hot. He darted into the room...

Then heard Cheyenne's voice: "Who's there?"

"Oh God," he sighed, palming his forehead. This swinging stuff could really mess with your nervous system. "Me," he called out.

Chey said, "Don't you knock?"

"I did," he said, coming to the bathroom's archway before entering. "Can I come in?"

"I'm not wearing anything," she said. Scarlet laughed.

“Fuck sake,” he muttered, wanting to say I’ve seen you naked, Chey, seen you naked with Cody doing the worst things imaginable, and for crying out loud, Scarlet put my penis in your mouth. “Well, can you put something on?”

“Can you go away and come back later?”

“What are you guys doing in there?”

“Girl stuff,” Chey said. “Not for your eyes, that’s for sure.”

He said, “Scarlet?”

“Yes?”

“Can I come in, please?”

She said, “Yes.”

But as he came around the corner, Cheyenne cried out with surprise and he put his hand up to block seeing something he shouldn’t.

Both women laughed at him. He lowered his hand and saw Scarlet’s head above the tub’s lip, soaking in bubbly water, her crimson hair tied up at the top, and Cheyenne fully clothed and seated on the tile floor beside the tub, the two of them close together like they’d been talking.

“You don’t look naked,” he said.

Chey said, “I dress really fast.”

“That’s great,” he said. “What are you guys doing?”

Chey looked around the room like it should be obvious.

He said, “What, you washing her back or something?”

Scarlet said, “We’re talking.”

“About what?” All he could think was his wife was gushing about how hot sex with Philippe had been, and he was dying to talk to her about it—he hadn’t seen her comatose since the wee hours of this morning. Chey shouldn’t get to hear about it first.

Cheyenne said, “We’re talking about stuff.”

“What stuff?”

Scarlet said, “Byron.”

“What about him?” It sounded like bullshit.

“She’s giving him another chance with Carla. Don’t tell him though.”

“It’s a surprise?”

Cheyenne said, “Yeah, I don’t want him to stress about it.”

“That’s nice of you. Why do you think he’ll stress?”

Both women clucked their tongues and rolled their eyes up, and he had no idea why. Scarlet said, “Never mind, Sully. Fucking Detective Columbo over here, has to know everything.”

He splayed his hands, irritated. “I’m just making conversation. . . . Hey, Chey, why don’t you...” He brushed backhands towards Cheyenne, indicating for her to skedaddle for a bit.

Cheyenne’s face contorted to disgust. “I was here first, why don’t *you*...” Now she brushed at him with fanning backhands.

He growled and pinched the bridge of his nose. “I’m here for a *reason*.”

“There’s a million toilets on this yacht, you gotta take a dump in this one?” Cheyenne said, staying seated on the floor. “What, you can’t be far from Scarlet? You guys hold hands, or— Oh no, is she still toilet training you?”

Scarlet laughed and made her bubbly bathtub water ripple.

He said, “Whose side are you on?”

Scarlet smiled and cocked her head to her friend. “Chey, can you give us a minute.”

“Fine,” Cheyenne said, pulling herself to stand using the wide lip of the circular tub. “I was leaving anyway.”

“Thank you,” he said, nodding to her with grace.

Chey patted his shoulder as she passed saying, “Don’t get any on the toilet seat, little buddy.”

Now he rolled his eyes, both Chey and Scarlet laughing as Chey left the bathroom and exited out the suite’s door. Sully turned to his wife and dropped down into the place Chey had been sitting.

“We might have a bit of a problem.”

“Paloma?”

His mouth was poised open, ready to launch into his news. He closed his mouth. “How’d you know?”

“Carla told me.” She raised a sudsy arm out of the tub and ran a sponge up and down it.

“Oh,” he said. “I feel let down now.”

“Who told you?”

“Byron. He texted me from the boat. He’s coming from shore with Cody and Paloma.”

“Okay,” she said.

“What’re we going to do? What’re we going to say?”

Scarlet sighed and let the sponge drop. “I don’t even know.”

“Is it a big deal?”

“I’m not sure... It could be.”

And suddenly all worry about Byron’s texted news seemed to dissipate and all he could think about was how beautiful Scarlet looked this way. Naked but obscured, feminine as fuck, no makeup, that thick mane of hair up on top of her head and showing off her swanlike neck. Last time he’d seen her she’d been strewn across the bed like a rag doll, sexually obliterated by him and another man. How was it everything could seem okay? First thing he’d said to her in the morning after was about different news, not about the thing they’d done together.

He slunk closer to her, leaning over the tub’s lip and taking her neck to guide her to his mouth for a kiss. She was accepting, her lips cool compared to their fevered heat last night. Just kissing this sexual creature got his blood pumping and his cock thickening. “I fucking love you,” he said.

She brushed a stray wisp of hair from her forehead with a wet hand. “I love you, too.”

“You look incredible.”

“Thank you,” she said, almost bashful.

“If it’s a problem, we’ll deal with it together. How bad could it be?”

Scarlet palmed his cheek, suds slipping down his neck. “Chey said Philippe and Paloma were trying to get back together...”

CHAPTER 2

Scarlet said to Sully as he climbed into the tub with her, “First of all, you can forget it.”

“Forget what?” Sully said, totally knowing what she meant.

As he slipped into the water across from her, his upright erection swallowed by bubbles, she said, “I’m closed for business.”

“You’re talking about my erection? Don’t flatter yourself. This erection has nothing to do with you.” He eased into the water, face transforming to ecstasy like he’d just injected heroin or something, his handsome features sagging downward, lips parting. It deflated his sly joke.

“Thoughts of Philippe?” As soon as she said it, she thought it sounded stupid—but Carla had put it in her head that her husband might have messed around with Philippe after they had rendered her useless and left her in a sex puddle on Philippe’s bed.

His sleeping eyes flickered open. “What was that?”

“You heard me. What’s got my man’s pecker so wooden if it’s not me?”

Sully grunted to dismiss her, folding his hands over his stomach under the mountain range of bubbles that separated them in Carla’s big round Jacuzzi

tub. His eyes fluttered open again. “Are you serious?”

“About you and Philippe?”

Sully looked irritated for a moment. “No,” he said. “About you being closed for business.”

“I just don’t want you putting any moves on me at the moment.”

“Are you sore?”

“What do you think?”

Sully sat straight now, eyes returned to normal, showing concern. “Are you really okay? You’re not hurt or something, are you?” His bare butt squeaked on the tub’s bottom as he scooted closer to her, his hands going to touch on either side of her waist. She raised her knees in automatic defense.

“I’m fine, baby.”

“I never thought of that,” he said, looking aside, stroking thumbs on her ribs. “And I just left you in bed without checking on you.”

“You know who looked out for me?—Carla.”

“What do you mean?”

“Brought me breakfast in bed.”

Sully grimaced, knowing that meant Carla knew she’d find Scarlet in Philippe’s bed. “She asked me point blank, babe. I couldn’t even lie, I just stood there stammering and she knew right away.”

“It’s fine, Sully,” she said, stroking his cheek. “That’s how I knew Paloma was coming. Carla told me.”

“Oh,” he said, nodding. “So, what do you think? About Paloma, I mean.”

“I freaked out at first, but now”—she shrugged a shoulder—“I don’t know what to think.”

“She’s Brazilian.”

“What does that mean? You think she knows jiu-jitsu or something? She’s from Rio, her dad was a diplomat, she’s not exactly some favela street fighter, babe.”

“I just mean she’s passionate.”

She raised her eyebrows. “I’m *not* passionate?”

“Oh my God,” he groaned, then dipped his mouth low and blew a cloud of bubbles that splatted on her neck. “I mean she might be mad even though we didn’t do anything wrong.”

“They lived in a polycule.”

“What is a polycule anyway, Scar?”

“I don’t know, it’s like it sounds.”

“It sounds like chemistry class.”

They both snickered and bowed their heads, touching hairlines. It had been a long and wild night for them both and this was the first time they had together since they’d slept. She put her hands on his shoulders and squeezed them.

Sully said, “Are we open about it with her?”

“Like I shake her hand, say hey, Paloma, long time no see. Me and Sully over there had a threesome with your ex last night.”

“Something like that.”

“Let’s play it by ear.”

“Did you tell Cheyenne?”

She screwed her mouth to one side. “Yeah. I told her. Are you going to tell Byron?”

“No. Or yeah. Maybe. What did Chey say?”

“She thought it was great. She knew it was going to happen.”

“Why are we hiding it from everyone then?”

Scarlet sighed and looked up at the wood paneled ceiling, scooping warm water onto Sully’s shoulders. “I guess it’s Lily and Arlo.”

“Yeah. I don’t know what they would think.”

“They must know something’s going on by now. . . . Hey, you know what’s funny? I told Chey about our night with Philippe— but I *didn’t* tell her something else...”

Sully’s eyebrows shot up, eager to hear some gossip. “Oh yeah? What didn’t you tell her?”

She licked her lower lip, smiling. “Carla told me she has the hots for Byron. Like the sexual hots. She told me she masturbates over him.”

Sully pulled back. “Oh, get real.”

“I think she was serious.”

“No, she wasn’t. She’s fucking with you.”

“No, she admitted it like it was this weird thing. Like she’s got a type and the type isn’t Cody.”

“Cody’s everybody’s type, Scarlet.”

“She said she likes boyish men. Like sleek and youthful.”

“*I’m* youthful.”

Her mouth pursed to a slim line and she studied her husband. He knew he was caught and looked away, trying to hide his grin. “Is that why you’re so dubious right now? You’re jealous of Byron.”

“I’m not jealous of Byron. And what the hell, you’re jealous *now*. Look at you getting mad at me after what we did last night.”

“I’m not mad.”

“Not mad,” he muttered. “Just superior.”

She eyed him, scratched the corner of her mouth. “I might be closed for business a lot longer than I thought.”

Sully said, “Closed to me or to everyone?”

Her expression and mood soured. “Maybe we shouldn’t joke around like this. I feel a little emotional.”

“Me too.”

“You’re not mad at me, are you?”

He shook his head no, expression serious.

“You can be mad.”

“I’m not. We did it together.”

“I tricked you into coming down to Philippe’s room.”

“Maybe you were right to do it.”

“Maybe.”

* * *

With the garlic cloves on an iron pan skimmed with ghee and roasting in the outdoor oven, Arlo began trimming sprigs of fresh thyme, looking to bundle them into a brush for basting the Mangalitza pork with later this evening, closer to dinner. Lily mounted the steps from the lower deck, book in hand, bookmark tassel swaying in the breeze. Under the shade of her sunhat Lily smiled, coming to join him in the outdoor kitchen. She looked at peace today with what he'd arranged for her last night, wearing her sensible two-piece swimsuit and a caftan, enjoying a vacation day reading outdoors. A very Lily thing to do—which made Arlo happy.

He asked her how her book was as she came into the kitchen area, and she told him it was good, sliding it onto a clean space on the countertop, then putting her arms around his neck and laying her cheek on his chest. He hugged her.

She said, "What are you making?"

"I'm going to do the pork tonight."

"Sounds great," she sighed. "How are you going to cook it?"

"Oven roasted. With fruit, but I don't know what kind yet."

"Apples are too rudimentary. Too expected."

"I'm thinking citrus."

"It's perfect," she whispered. She slunk her light body against his, and he hugged her tighter. The drone of an approaching boat got both of them loosening their clutch and turning toward the shore side of the yacht. They strolled to the hand railing together, then watched the small white speedboat

on the horizon zip straight toward them, jouncing on the bright turquoise waves.

Lily said, “It’s so weird Paloma’s coming. I mean, not in a bad way, just... it’s surprising. I thought they weren’t together anymore, and that it was official. Like paperwork official.”

“Paperwork means little in affairs of the heart, Lily.”

“That’s so true, baby.”

“If she misses him and he misses her, no paperwork can keep them apart. And when you sign papers, when you deal with bureaucrats, there’s no magic anymore. Lawyers will sell you on duty and protocol, but that’s all it is: salesmanship. It was probably the draw of protocol that got the ball rolling, and once that ball is rolling it’s not the lovers in charge anymore. There’s someone else behind the wheel. Then when the bureaucrats are gone, the heart suffers.”

Lily squeezed next to him and put her arms around his waist while they watched the boat get close enough to see the passengers; Byron and Paloma standing, Cody manning the controls behind aviator sunglasses.

Lily said, “I love you.”

“I love you, too, baby,” he said, and kissed the top of her head.

As the boat slowed down its motors and veered toward the rear of the yacht, Cody spotted them and waved. Arlo waved in return, but Lily hugged Arlo tighter. He chuckled and smoothed his arms on her back, knowing what his wife thought of Cody right now.

Without saying anything, they both followed along the hand railing, down the steps to the lower deck to where Lily had been reading, and went to watch Cody steer the boat to the yacht’s back bay. The bay doors retracted,

the panels clattering as they rolled upward. From where they stood, he and Lily could watch the speedboat enter the bay where the boat and the wave runners were stored.

Lily said, “What about all the bad things Philippe’s been up to on the boat? How do you think Paloma will take that?”

“That’s for them to decide, baby.”

“All the men here are naughty.”

He chuckled, picturing Lily’s surly face, her pink lips pooched out. “All men are bad, Lily.”

“Except you.” Then she darted her head around to make sure they were alone and no one overheard them, adding then: “Daddy.”

“Sh-shh,” he said, putting his arm around her and holding her close again. Down below, the speedboat entered the channel between the two swimming docks, and Byron steadied the boat against the railing, deciding to disembark at one of the swimming docks instead of the boat garage. Byron’s hair was a tangled mess from the wind, but Paloma wore a sunhat not unlike Lily’s. Byron stepped off, a little unsteady after bouncing around the speedboat, but he returned to give Paloma a hand. Cody was talking but couldn’t be heard from the higher deck they were on.

Lily said, “Was it Cody?”

It was the first time she’d asked him the direct question. Last night all she’d wanted was to cuddle and forget what had happened. He said, “You don’t want to know, Lily.”

“I do, Daddy,” she said, the trace of a whine in her voice. Then quieter, “It wasn’t Byron.”

“No,” he admitted.

“So Cody or Sully,” she said.

“Or Philippe.”

“It wasn’t Philippe,” she said.

He sighed, a heavy feeling over his heart. If she wanted to know, he would tell her. He set her back and turned her to face him. The brim of her sunhat sagged and he had to fold it up to see her eyes. “Do you *have* to know?”

Her lips pooched then she sucked them in, her mouth squirming around, her eyes shifty, but then returning to settle her gaze on his. “I don’t have to but I *want* to.”

He said, “It wasn’t Sully and it wasn’t Cody.”

Her eyebrows rose. “It wasn’t Cody?”

“I swear it wasn’t.”

A small creeping smile began, and she narrowed her eyes. “It was you, wasn’t it?” She beat him once on the chest with her small fist. He gathered the fist between his two hands and held it over his heart. As Lily watched him, her features began to fall as she saw there was more to the story.

He shook his head no.

She whispered, “It wasn’t you?”

“Lily, honey... what if I told you it wasn’t *any* of our friends on the boat?”

Lily’s eyes widened with fear.

CHAPTER 3

Sully had come into the bathroom just as Scarlet prepared to deliver the dirty details to Cheyenne. While the revelation was shocking, Scarlet's threesome had seemed inevitable, given all that had happened so far on their yacht vacation. It was probably all Chey's fault. She'd been the one who'd succumbed to another man's charm, after all. And her swinging experience had been positive. Positive bordering on cathartic. Not just for her, but for her relationship with her husband. The more she'd discussed it with Scarlet, the more it pushed Scarlet to taking her own first step into the dark side.

So, while Scarlet's threesome with her husband and Philippe was an outrageous spectacle that would stupefy her a month ago—hell, even a few days ago—somehow she'd been inured to the surprise of Scarlet's wild night of three-way sex.

"It's so good to see you again, Cheyenne," Paloma said, taking Chey's hands and kissing the air next to both cheeks, the wide brim of the sunhat Paloma wore scooting across the top of Cheyenne's head.

Cheyenne laughed. Not at the greeting, but how her reverie had swallowed her, taken her mind away from greeting Paloma in the second floor lounge.

The magnetic attraction of these yacht-based sexual endeavors had stolen her brain.

“It’s such a surprise to have you here,” Cheyenne said.

Paloma said, “A pleasant one, I hope.”

“Of course,” Chey said, chuckling. There was more she wanted to say, but given the situation, she didn’t want to say the wrong thing. Philippe had told her secrets, and she didn’t want to say something that would reveal that to Paloma. Philippe missed Paloma, and Chey hoped they would get back together. She would hate to wreck it for Philippe by saying the wrong thing.

Byron joined her, putting his arm around the small of her back. Cody stood behind Paloma, carrying her bags. Byron had carried up the others, the suitcases on wheels. A brief pause of uncomfortable silence was broken at last as Arlo and Lily came down from the deck above and joined them, Lily following behind her husband with an unusual expression.

Arlo gestured with both palms held out, showing Paloma how happy he was to see her. The two of them had always got along. Paloma was more proper, more like Lily and Arlo—though, given all she knew about Paloma, maybe that wasn’t true. *A polycule.*

Arlo greeted Paloma with a warm hug and then Lily took her turn—still sporting an unusual expression—then shifted in behind Arlo as Arlo told Paloma how happy he was she could join them.

Paloma had always been a hard one to peg when they all got together. Quiet and reserved, yet after a cocktail or two she could be funny. Maybe even endearing. Scarlet thought Paloma could be haughty, but they’d always got along.

Lily and Arlo departed their conversation with Paloma, stepping away and opening up the group, turning so they faced the same direction Paloma faced. Chey turned to follow their gazes.

Past the lounge, beyond the glass partition wall, on the far side of the dining room, Philippe headed their way. None of them said a thing, only watched Philippe walk toward them, and the silence inflated to the point of bursting; Chey's forearms bristled with goosebumps, wondering what Philippe and Paloma's greeting would be like. Was Philippe as surprised as everyone else that Paloma was here? Was he happy Paloma was here?

Philippe had told her how he and Paloma and two other couples had lived in a commune, upstate, in the woods. Three couples, six people, all in open relationships. But only open amongst the six people of their commune. Paloma had strayed outside the commune, but Philippe still loved her. But, he'd said, as much as he loved Paloma, rules were rules, and the rules were all they had that could keep them together. It sounded harsh to Chey when Philippe had told her about it, but he'd said don't think of it as a relationship, think of it as a society. He'd said he had a duty to their society, their *community*, to enforce the rules. If he didn't enforce the rules, how would the others trust him?

It sounded terrible. It sounded like banishment.

Philippe now reached the partition and entered the lounge, close enough to hear the gum soles of his moccasins on the polished wood floor. One side of his mustache lifted in a slight smile. His dark eyes twinkled with magical compassion. The potential for witnessing a warm reunion set off a kaleidoscope of happy butterflies in Cheyenne's tummy.

* * *

It was like they'd never been apart. The way Philippe took Paloma in his arms, the way Paloma melted against Philippe, it was like they weren't divorced at all, it was like they'd been separated by distance, by travel, two lovers living on different continents now reunited after a long divide. It warmed Byron's heart, and he took Cheyenne's hand and squeezed it. It had no life. He turned to regard his wife. Chey was in deep focus, watching the reunion the way he did, but her eyes narrowed and burning like laser beams. He double-squeezed her hand, and she leaned close, leading with her ear but not taking her eyes off Philippe and Paloma.

He whispered, "That's so nice, don't you think?"

"I know," she said, still watching them. Arlo and Lily beamed, though Lily looked a little sick, and Cody smiled wide too, nodding with some respect. A happy reunion indeed.

Byron said, "It's a great surprise, eh, buddy?"

Philippe let Paloma go, Paloma going back down to her heels as her former husband released her. Her smile was big and beautiful. Her eyes happy, shining with wet.

"It's a great surprise," Philippe said, still holding one of Paloma's hands.

Byron said to Paloma, "Where am I taking your bags?" Cheyenne elbowed him and he shot her an innocent look.

Paloma and Philippe looked at one another. Philippe said, "We'll bring them down to my room."

* * *

Cheyenne stayed alone in the lounge wishing Scarlet would show up—but didn't blame her friend for hanging back, given she'd slept with Philippe

last night. After about ten minutes, she texted Byron asking him where he was and waited for his reply. Cody and Byron had gone with Philippe and Paloma with Paloma's bags and Lily and Arlo had returned upstairs where Arlo was preparing a meal for tonight, welcoming Paloma. Byron got back to her, saying he was headed to the kitchen, where was she, and did she want him to make her a cocktail. She told him she would love a cocktail and she would meet him in the kitchen in fifteen minutes. Then she went to the far end of the yacht, toward the bow or whatever you call it, to the second set of stairs that would take her to the level below.

She crept down the stairs on high alert, eyes darting, ears listening. When she was sure the coast was clear, and no one saw her sneaking, she made her way through the lower lounge to the archway that led to the center hall where the lower level suites were. Where Philippe's suite was. Philippe's and Paloma's. She listened, heard nothing, chanced a look. The hall was empty.

She crept the hall, ready to assume a more nonchalant pose should someone catch her, going on quiet careful footsteps, hands in her pockets, slowing as she neared the end of the hall, close to the last door on her right, Philippe's room. Where her friend and her friend's husband had a threesome. She looked up and down the hall, ensuring the coast was still clear. Then she edged to the door and inclined her head to listen.

Beyond the heavy door she could hear Philippe and Paloma talking, Paloma laughing her light sound, even her laugh tinged with that Brazilian-English sound, with some German and Portuguese. But she couldn't make out the words. She edged even closer, getting her ear almost touching the door.

From close behind her, a click and a male voice: "What you up to, Chey?"

Her heart jumped, and she almost swallowed her tongue, snapping away from the door and turning, folding her arms across her chest. Her pulse

pounded, her heart raced, and her cheeks burned. Cody had come out of the room next to Philippe's, carrying extra pillows under an arm.

"You scared the shit out of me," she whispered.

"Sorry," he whispered back. He looked to the door where she'd been huddled, then back to her, a mischievous look on his handsome face. "Man, I *love* spying, Chey. Me and some of the guys took twelve hours once, sneaking up on this farmhouse in Afghanistan, all these goats and shit, and then when it's night, we got our night-vision—"

"Well, I don't have night-vision right now, Cody— Hey, you don't have night-vision goggles here or anything, do you?"

"No," he said, laughing. "Why would I have that here? At home, sure. But *here*?" He turned to look at Philippe's door and then faced her again. "Why're we spying on my buddy?"

"You don't want to know what they're talking about?"

"He'll tell me later."

"He's probably not going to tell *me*."

"So, what? That means you gotta creep around outside his room? Tell you what, you want a tip? You go in this room next door to his, it's empty, you see, and you can put a water glass up to the wall..."

"That works?"

"Sure it does. Or, how about this? I'll tell you what he tells me. How about that?"

She smiled and narrowed her eyes on him. "Can I trust you?"

Cody recoiled as if mortally wounded by her words, clutching at his chest, his big, good-looking tanned hand clutching a handful of his tank top. He smelled so fucking good. She laughed and grabbed his wrist and he pulled her in for a one-armed hug, pillows under his other arm. “Don’t worry,” he said, “I got your back.” To prove it, he swatted her bottom.

The unprovoked and unexpected feel of his hand slapping her ass got her clenching her muscles and going on her toes, an out-of-the-blue sexual feeling shivering through her. She pressed together her knees, squirming against his hard and muscular body. She changed the subject. “You think they’re going to get back together?”

“I don’t know. It’s a good sign, don’t you think, Paloma coming all this way?”

“The Grand Gesture.”

“What’s that?”

“Something I like better when guys do it.”

“Sounds dirty, Chey. You be careful talking to me like that. Might be the middle of the day, but you can get me horned up with just a little wink.”

She looked up into his turquoise eyes, getting lost in them a moment, then saying, “I better be careful then.”

“Or reckless,” he said, “depending on what you wanted.” Now his hand dipped down her lower back, and instead of swatting her bottom he coddled it, his fingers stroking over the under curved of her cheeks and setting off her tickle buttons as he got closer to where her sex hid. She stepped away from him, giggling, hiding her nipples with folded arms; they’d tightened at his masculine touch.

“You want to teach me this Grand Gesture sometime soon, Chey? Sounds intriguing.”

She said, “It’s for people in love, Cody. In love, but apart. The Grand Gesture can bring them back together if the other is willing.”

Cody nodded. “You think Philippe’s going to accept Paloma’s Grand Gesture?”

“That’s what I was here to find out.”

“You’re a curious little kitty cat, aren’t you?”

She shrugged, smirking, feeling embarrassed and hoping her incomplete claim was enough to stop Cody’s questions.

“I get curious, too, sometimes,” Cody said.

“I’m sure you do.”

“Like, you know this thing you’re cooking up for Byron?”

“Uh-huh.”

“What are you and *I* going to do when it’s going down?”

“You and me? That might take the selflessness out of it.”

“That’s what it’s about? You and how you feel?”

She scowled. “No, it’s just about him.”

Cody’s mouth turned down, not out of disappointment or disagreeableness, but out of an assessment and approval of her stated motive. “I like it,” he said, then swatted her butt again, stepping away now, ready to go into Philippe and Paloma’s room, delivering the extra pillows. Then he paused

and turned back, that handsome hand rubbing at his chest. “I love the way your nipples rub on me when you’re horny.”

Man, and there went those butterflies again, flitting up from her nether regions to tickle throughout her torso. She rolled her eyes and then growled as if irritated—smiling like a schoolgirl the whole time—then trotted up the stairs to meet Byron, Cody chuckling behind her.

CHAPTER 4

Scarlet met Chey coming up the stairs. Chey was bustling.
“Hey, I was looking for you,” Scarlet said.

Chey moved like she didn’t want to stop, getting one step higher than Scarlet before pausing to turn. “Hey,” she said, almost breathless, “what’s up?”

“What’s up with you? Your cheeks are all red. What were you doing?”

“Oh,” Chey said, chuckling, scratching her head. She leaned on the handrail, one hip sticking out. “I was just, you know, poking around.”

Chey’s poking around intrigued her, and she stepped closer. “Poking around about what?”

Chey exhaled, lips pooching out, eyes shifting aside. “I’m not sure yet.”

Scarlet’s face jutted closer to Chey’s, eyes narrowing. “But you’re poking with purpose?”

Chey nodded. “So how was your bath?”

“Tell me what you’re poking around about.”

“You know Paloma’s here, right?”

“Yeah, I know,” she said in a flat tone.

“I’m poking around about that.”

“You said Philippe wanted to work it out with her.”

“I did.”

Scarlet studied Chey’s face, her posture, reading her friend. She was alert but distracted, her cheeks blushed—wait, her nipples showed through the fabric of her shirt. “But you think something’s up?”

“I don’t know yet.”

“We need to find somewhere to talk. I didn’t even get to tell you about last night...”

“We do,” Chey said. “We do have to talk.”

“Where do you want to go?”

“Meet me... Meet me on the swimming deck— No, wait, meet me on the top deck.”

“The helicopter pad?”

“No, no, the one under that.” Chey began to back her way up the stairs, but Scarlet had been searching for Chey, not headed down the stairs, so she followed her. Chey stopped, saying, “Meet me there in ten. No, uh, fifteen.”

“Where are you going?”

“To find Byron. He’s making me a cocktail.”

“I’ll come with.”

Chey stopped her with a hand.

* * *

Two perfect G & Ts, if he said so himself. Strong. Strong the way Chey liked it. Two gin to five tonic, and the good tonic, too. Tonic Arlo brought, some expensive looking British stuff from India with high quinine and a hint of ginger and mandarin. Lots of ice. Two slices of lime.

“Hey, babe,” he said with pride as Chey hustled into the kitchen. “Perfect timing.”

Chey swished around the marble island and into the workspace with him, passing by his well-presented cocktails, and looping her arms around his neck and kissing him. He laughed at her eagerness, his heart swelling in his chest with the excitement of her welcome greeting. His hands went to her sides—wow, she was warm—and eased her back.

“I’d make cocktails on the hour every hour if I knew this would be the reaction.”

Chey, with her arms around his neck still, looked over her shoulder to where the cocktail glasses were. She let him go and picked one up.

“The tonic water’s from India. Arlo must have brought it. It’s got—”

But Chey wasn’t listening. She took a big drink, and while he waited to hear what she thought, she didn’t *stop* drinking. Just gulp-gulp-gulp, tilting the glass higher, stretching her throat, and draining his well-made cocktail. She set the empty glass down, the ice cubes clinking, and launched her kiss to his again, hugging his neck.

Her plump lips were ice cold and lemon-lime and so fucking sexy. His heart pounded in his chest as her kisses moved from his mouth to his chin then to

his neck, her hands working with frantic need to unzip his shorts. Now he was panting, slumping back against the edge of the counter and looking up at the ceiling and wondering how the hell this was happening. Chey went to her knees. He palmed his forehead. She got his limp cock out of his zipper, and into her cold mouth it went. The feel of her mouth on him, so unexpected, in the middle of the day, in a sunny kitchen where anyone could walk in, had his cock going hard and straight in about ten heartbeats. Chey made satisfied sounds feeling him grow erect in her mouth. Then she was standing again, her hands going all over his body.

“Take me somewhere,” she gasped. “Do whatever you want to me.”

“For sure.”

She put her forehead against his, eye-locking him. “But whatever it is, you have to do it hard.”

“I can do that.”

Then she bit her own lips, chest heaving, twisting his shirt in her grip. She groaned. “Fuck, baby, there’s no time.”

“No time for what?”

She looked over both shoulders, backing away from him and turning, her elbows moving in and out as she unbuttoned and unzipped her shorts. He watched in will-eyed amazement as his wife pushed her shorts down, shimmying her hips, her panties going too. Her bare ass was revealed in the bright kitchen sunlight.

“Holy shit.”

Now she put her elbows on the counter, sticking her ass out, presenting her sex. It was full and engorged and shining with wet. He couldn’t remember a time when Cheyenne had been this abruptly horny.

“What are we doing?” But despite his own whispered question, he was already on his wife’s back, thumbing his aching boner into her hot wet seam and driving inside her body. The satisfied sound she made curled his toes against the foam beds of his slides.

“Oh, god,” she panted. “Hard, baby. Hard, Byron.”

“Someone could walk in,” he grunted, humping her into the counter as hard as he could, hooking one arm around her, Cheyenne gripping it, digging her nails into his flesh.

“Then, hurry, oh, hurry—make me come.”

His free hand dove down her front side, across the flat of her tummy, between her thighs and to her pussy. It was slick and hot, and it took no effort to find her swollen clit in the nest of swollen membranes. Her legs trembled when he pleased it.

“You’re so fucking wet, Chey. Why are you so wet?”

“That fuckin’ what’s-his-name,” she hissed.

“Cody?” A spike of adrenalin flared up red blobs in his vision. They burst with the goo of anger but dissipated to nothing. He chuckled, hugging her with one arm, the other hand mushing and swirling into her clitoris, getting her moaning, getting her head rocking. “But you come to me.”

She made sounds of hot lust, thrashing her hair around while he fucked her from behind, standing, mastering her orgasm closer in a way he didn’t anticipate he could.

Chey bit his wrist and the sexiness of that got his balls hugging his shaft with looming excitement. Then she blubbered, “He wasn’t even a cowboy, he was just fuckin’...”

As she came close to saying Carla's husband's name, she began seizing and bucking. He chased her clit as her body's orgasmic convulsions threatened to tear her away from him, making her mewl and cry with ecstasy. And just like that, he exploded too, grunting and grumbling as he ejaculated inside his horny wife—his wife made horny by another man. Made horny by another man, admitting it, okay with it, coming to her husband for what she needed. As the wild pleasure of his orgasm enfolded his consciousness, he felt a funny pride, and a closeness to the woman he loved. They'd come to a strange point in their marriage, breaching some rampart and landing in a happy garden where his feelings and her feeling were harder to hurt.

They both chuckled and giggled, ticklishness thrilling them as he withdrew his slippery penis from inside her. He grabbed paper towel from the under cabinet roll and cleaned her off before taking care of himself. Then they donned their shorts before anyone caught them. They were lucky to get away with it.

He collapsed against the counter as Chey turned to face him again, her eyes shining and happy. She looked a lot different than the bundle of nerves who'd thundered into the kitchen a moment ago and drained her cocktail in one go.

He said, "Feel better?"

She laughed and fell against him, kissing his lips again, all the cold gone from the heat they'd produced.

* * *

When Carla went back inside the yacht, he knew Lily would be on him right away. They'd come up to the outdoor kitchen prep and found Carla

resuming her work as his *sous*, chopping onions. She'd gone inside now to clean her hands with lemon, as he'd advised.

Lily turned from where she'd been mixing a batter in a stainless bowl and getting next to him, trying to catch his eye.

Without regarding her, he said, "What is it?"

She touched his arm, and he stopped tying the roast, wiping his hands and regarding her very serious face. Her beautiful eyes were wide and trembling. He touched her chin with his thumb, but she disregarded it, saying, "Please, tell me it wasn't."

"Wasn't what, Lily?"

"Not what, Daddy. You know what I'm saying. Not *what*—*who*. Wasn't *who*."

"I shouldn't have told you anything at all. That's why we did it the way we did it. He wanted to be anonymous."

"That's not fair," she said, sharp and surly.

"Hey," he said, stern. "You knew the rules, and you accepted them."

"I *hate* him," she said.

He cocked his head, showing her a serious, no-fun expression. "It hadn't occurred to you it might be him?"

Those trembling eyes of hers grew wet and pink and she turned away, put her back to him, sniffing. She said something, and he didn't hear it.

"What was that?"

She sniffled more, sighed for dramatic effect, being a baby. "Not out here," she said, voice thick with emotion.

He chuckled. He loved it when she was young and petulant and silly, but it demanded so much from him. What it demanded from him he loved to deliver, though. His Lily needed a responsible man. A disciplined man. A creative one who could be everything she needed him to be. He went to her then, being strong, being confident; strong enough to deliver to his wife even the things she was reluctant to hear. His hands went over her bare shoulders and he kissed the back of her silky blond head. "Lily, honey..."

"It's just not fair, Daddy. You *betrayed* me."

"I'll send you to your room, Lily."

"*Good*," she said, sulky.

"You don't mean that, Lily." His voice was soft but the tone heavy with implication. Lily said no more to defy him or to anger him. She stayed silent.

They stayed that way for a long while, his front to her back, the sea breeze cutting across the deck toward the shore, the air warm. At last Lily whispered. "Was it him, or are you just being mean to me?"

Arlo turned her to face him. She was adorable; her cute little mouth pursed to a defiant plump little pink dollop; her chin dimpled, her brow low and mean, but so much sweet timid innocence beaming from his wife's big, beautiful eyes.

"I make the decisions, Lily. The big ones, the hard ones. I make the decisions I don't even want to make. I make them for us. I make them for you. I didn't betray you."

Her eyes rolled around in a way that told him all sorts of rebukes cascaded around her brain; things she wanted to say if she knew they wouldn't put her over his knee.

This is bullshit. You're bullshit. Everything is bullshit.

But she was a good girl and said nothing. He pointed to her mixing bowl and told her to get back to work.

CHAPTER 5

An hour before dinner, Byron met Sully for a beer on the shadiest deck, sitting at a table in front of the glass wall that displayed the bluish inside of the yacht's swimming pool. Byron asked Sully what he made of Paloma's arrival and Sully took a long time to think about it, holding his beer bottle against his chest, slumped in the chair and looking out at the sea. The sun was beginning to descend, and the sky, though still blue, had taken on a baked golden hue.

Sully took another sip and then regarded Byron. "Scarlet and I messed around last night. . . . And, you know, Philippe was there."

Byron narrowed his eyes, trying to decipher the clunky statement. "You mean you guys had a threesome?"

Sully nodded, looking down at his bottle, lips puckered, chewing his cheek.

Byron's scalp prickled, thinking about it. "Was it good or..."

"It was good. No, definitely good."

"But...?"

"Oh," he said, looking up again. "But nothing." He took a swig from his beer then said. "Everything's different now, though, you know?"

“You think I don’t know.”

Sully looked over. “I know you know.”

“At least half the yacht wasn’t in on it.”

“Like with you? I thought you wanted that?”

“Chey wanted it.” But that wasn’t true. “No, I wanted it, too.”

“You led the way, my man.” Sully held up his beer in a toast.

“I did. So... Like, what; you didn’t lead the way?”

“Maybe that’s it,” Sully said, sighing.

“There’s an it? What is the *it*?”

Sully blubbered a long exhale. “I don’t know, I guess I’m okay with it and everything, but I can’t take it back.”

“*It* being what, the threesome?”

“Yup, the threesome. It was good. I was into it. . . . It was *great*, actually. We all had a good time. I just mean that... Geez, I don’t know.”

“You had a good time, but the shine is off the sanctity of your marriage?”

Sully grunted, smiling. “That’s pretty insightful, Byron. Yeah, good job. That’s it.”

“Ah, it’s overblown,” he said. “Sanctity’s like a comparative term. Don’t let how you would compare your marriage to another’s, past or present, to describe your marriage. Like me and Chey, what we did, I probably feel the same way you do in the aftermath, but I don’t think any less of my marriage. I only worry how others would consider it compared to their own. But why would I care about that? Chey and I don’t have children yet, and

what happened doesn't make me feel displaced from her in any way. I feel *closer* to her."

"I feel closer to Scarlet," Sully muttered.

"Then what's the big deal?"

"Who said there was a big deal?"

"You, with your glum face staring off into the sunset."

"Excuse me for having thoughts in my head."

"Excuse me for trying to help you."

They both laughed and stared off into the sunset.

Byron said, "Did Scarlet really have sex with Philippe?"

"Uh-huh."

"Crazy."

Sully said, "Go on and ask."

"How? Like *how*, with that thing...?"

"It wasn't easy. But it was crazy hot, buddy, making out with her while she was on top of him."

Byron adjusted his shorts at the sudden mental image that provoked, getting aroused when he hadn't expected he would. "Hoo boy."

"Hoo boy is right."

Later when the sun was lower and their beers were empty Byron confessed what was on his mind. "I want to be with Carla again."

"You should. Why wouldn't you?"

“I’m going to, I just...”

“Everything became about Chey. And me and Chey.”

“So?... Oh no, *performance anxiety*?”

“Don’t say that. You *never* say that. It’s like saying break a leg to an actor; don’t be supportive—you’ll jinx me.”

“Fine then, bro. Break a dick.”

They both laughed and Sully added, “Carla will probably do that for you.”

Byron admitted, “She’s well-versed in the, uh... dark arts of sex.”

“Are you really intimidated? What changed since the last time?”

Sully thought the last time had gone a lot different than it had and Byron wasn’t ready for that admission yet. He shrugged, not sure what to say.

Sully made a funny face then looked around like he had a secret. Byron leaned closer, frowning. “What is it?”

Sully said, “Carla told Scarlet she has the hots for you. Like the only way Cody could be with Cheyenne was because Carla wanted to be with you first.”

Byron stared at him, waiting for the joke. When it didn’t come, he broke a smile of his own, slinking back in his chair. “Get the fuck out of here.”

Sully laughed too, saying, “That’s what I said when Scarlet told me—no offense, buddy—but you know what Scarlet said?”

“Let me hear it,” Byron said, disbelieving already.

Sully checked over his shoulder again, then whispered, “She like... diddles herself to you.”

Byron rolled his eyes. “Why are you doing this to me?”

Sully laughed, leaning the chair back on its rear legs, putting his feet on the railing. “I’m not kidding. Take what you want from it, believe it or not, I’m telling you what Scarlet told me. She had a heart to heart with Carla and that’s what Carla told Scarlet. She has a thing for boyish men.”

Byron grunted, replaying some of Carla’s talks with him, looking for some truth to what he was hearing. He didn’t recall anything that would verify it, but nothing that would counter it either. “Crazy.”

Sully let his chair thump down, turned and faced Byron like he’d just received a grand revelation. “I got it, dude. A threesome...”

“What about one?”

Sully wagged an index finger between himself and Byron. “A threesome, Byron. You, me and Carla. What do you think?”

* * *

Sully doubted it would happen but still thought it was a good idea. If Byron got cold feet, he’d be happy to step in for a minute and give him a break from Carla, keep the party going, as it were. Maybe they could spring the idea on Carla and make it happen fast before Byron had too much time to think about it. Though Byron didn’t seem keen.

Would it matter? Because how would Scarlet feel about it? That’s what interested him now. He’d hardly seen her today except for their time in Carla’s tub, and that had been strange. Then she’d spent part of the afternoon drinking with Cheyenne up on the top of the yacht.

Now it was meal time and they were on the dining deck, ready to receive another grand slam dinner from their soon-to-be-famous chef friend. Scarlet

was at his side, looking refreshed after a long day of rest and hydration following her evening of devastating sex.

And the man with whom they'd shared a bed had been reunited with his estranged wife today.

Philippe sat near the head of the table and looked pleased as punch to have Paloma with him. It was kind of heartwarming to think that they could go through trials and tribulations that led to the downfall of their marriage and yet, with some time apart, could miss one another and long for the old times and feel love again.

What Sully didn't like was how Scarlet seemed disgruntled with Paloma's presence. Like she harbored jealous feelings. One night with this other man and she wanted to engage in a catfight over his affections.

How *powerful* was Philippe's fucking sexuality?

His wife divorces him, but comes running back to be with him. Probably addicted to the D. Scarlet spends one night with the guy and now she can't hide from her husband the displeasure she sees in her fling's reunion with his ex.

And, damn, Philippe's former wife looked hotter than ever. All tanned and glossy hair, those long legs that shone like she rubbed moisturizer on them three or four times a day. Big old smile, too, shiny lips, bright teeth. Dazzling, really.

Cody asked them all to stand and raise a glass. First he thanked Arlo and Lily for their hospitality, making such a wonderful meal, and Arlo once again thanked Carla for helping prep. Carla looked well-liquored; happy and hazy-eyed, speculative, too. Or maybe sneaky. Her eyes narrowed and glimmering with some secret knowledge.

Then Cody asked everyone to toast their surprise guest of honor. Paloma.

Paloma addressed everyone, standing tall and beautiful, saying, “Thank you, everyone,” in her hint-of-Rio accent, “it’s so good to be here with you all again. It’s an honor, really, and I’m glad you all welcome me.” She nodded then, gracious, one long, graceful arm folded across her middle, Philippe then standing next to her, taking her hand and kissing her cheek. Paloma folded arms around his neck and kissed his mouth, and most everyone said *aw*. Not Chey, though, and not Scarlet.

Sully shook his head, grumbling to himself, clapping his hands. Byron wolf-whistled and Cheyenne elbowed him. They all sat down to their meal.

As Arlo explained the dish he’d prepared, some kind of Hungarian pork or something, Sully leaned closer to Scarlet. “Why are *you* so sour?”

She looked at him like he was crazy. “Who says I’m sour?”

“The look on your face.”

She squinted, and showed him a look of incomprehension. “What are you talking about?”

“I thought you didn’t care Paloma was coming?”

“I don’t. Not really.”

“Yeah, not really,” he said, muttering to himself, “you just look like you’re watching someone drink the last bottle of water on a life raft.”

“What was that?”

“Nothing.”

Scarlet stared at the side of his head. “*I’m* the one who’s sour?”

“I’m not sour,” he said.

“I’m not either.”

“Good. We’re a couple of sweet candies then, right?”

“No sours here.”

“Good.”

Scarlet returned to face Arlo.

He leaned closer to her, saying, “Hey, Byron wants me to tag in on a three way with Carla.” See how she liked that one.

He watched her profile as she pretended to ignore him. Then instead of getting mad, she began to smile. She quarter-turned to him, whispering, “We’ll talk about it later.”

“Sure thing,” he said, wondering what she thought of it since she didn’t make it clear. Then he began to feel petty and unsure of why he was trying to charge her up, get her going. He said, “Let me know if you want to come along.”

She shook with a quiet laugh, then slunk nearer to him. “I want you to keep your thing in your shorts until I get to talk to you. Can you do that?”

“I didn’t see you all day.”

Now she showed a little compassion, touching his face. “I missed you.”

“I missed you, too,” he said.

“Promise me you won’t put your dick in anything until we talk.”

“You know I wouldn’t.”

“Okay,” she said, nodding, somewhat amused. “We’re going to be careful. Capice?”

There was something more to what she was saying, but for the life of him he had no idea what it was. He shook his head, looking for clarification. “Careful about what?”

Scarlet shushed him with a finger pressed to her lips, returning to her place setting as Lily began to serve their dinner.

CHAPTER 6

Right after dessert—chocolate ganache and a *perfect* dacquoise—Scarlet stood and announced she would do the dishes. Then she turned to Sully. “Do you want to help me?”

Sully showed her an expression of secret reproach, and she flared her nostrils and widened her eyes, beaming telepathic messages to her one-step-behind husband.

“Oh, yeah,” Sully said then, setting down his ice wine. “Yeah, let me give you a hand.” He began stacking dishes.

Cheyenne said, “I’m going to help, too. You guys stay here and talk.” She gestured to Philippe and Paloma and Arlo and Lily and Carla.

Byron didn’t need to be asked, joining in with Cheyenne to gather up dirty serving bowls and cutlery, but as they all went into the kitchen, Carla began to help as well, following behind them. Even Arlo and Lily came along.

In the kitchen, Scarlet scolded them, saying, “What are *you* doing in here? We said *we* were doing the dishes, you guys were so nice making such a an amazing dinner.”

“We’re just helping bring the stuff in,” Carla said, adding, “the next time we do this, we should just have staff on the yacht. Cody said he didn’t want them, but...” She shrugged and looked around at all the work that had to be done.

Cheyenne set a stack of plates down, saying, “Don’t worry about it. I like it when it’s just us on here, anyway. We don’t have to watch what we say. Besides, there are like two dishwashers in here.”

Byron said, “There’s four.”

“No, dishwashing machines,” Cheyenne said, and Byron laughed and pecked her lips. Cheyenne hugged him.

Lily and Arlo went into the kitchen, setting their stacks of plates down. Lily muttered, “I’m going to stay and help.”

Cheyenne said, “Oh-no you’re not, Lily.”

“I’d rather stay and help,” Lily said and began rinsing plates.

Arlo stood watching her, the slightest look of concern on his face. “Are you sure?”

“I’m sure,” Lily said, turning and holding a rinsed plate. She gave Arlo a strange look and Scarlet’s eyes darted from Arlo and Lily to Cheyenne and to Sully. Lily opened the dishwasher, ready to set her rinsed plate in. Cheyenne said again for her to go sit at the table and that they would take care of the dishes. Lily stood scowling with her lips pursed.

Arlo said, “You can stay if you want, but I’d like you to come back with me and sit at the table.”

“Why do I always have to do what you say?”

“You don’t have to do what I say, Lily,” Arlo explained. “If you’d like to stay and do dishes, you may. But I’d prefer it if—”

“I *may*?” Lily scowled. “You would *prefer*?”

Arlo said her name in a low warning. “Lily...”

Scarlet looked to Cheyenne, and Cheyenne looked surprised.

Lily said to Arlo, “Lily *what*?”

“It’s up to you what you want to do.”

“That’s what you say *now*.”

When have I ever *not* said that?”

“Oh, I don’t know,” she said. “So, I can do anything I want?”

“You can do anything you want.”

Lily then stood straighter, raised her chin in strange defiance to Arlo, offered out the plate to him with both hands. Then in one simple motion she parted her hands and let the plate drop to the floor where it shattered. Everyone jumped back as chips of china scattered on the floor.

Arlo uttered his wife’s name in stern warning again.

Lily folded her arms and stared at Arlo. “What if I don’t like your rules?”

Arlo looked around at the rest of them like Lily was being crazy. He said to Lily, “I don’t have any rules for you.”

“No,” she said. “No rules. No rules at all. You’ll just let anything happen. Anything. Anyone...”

“Lily, are you sure you want to...”

Lily grumbled as if irritated, pivoted on a heel and stomped out of the kitchen.

Cheyenne showed Scarlet a look of utter shock, her eyebrows lifted high, her eyes wide. *Holy shit.*

Carla stepped forward and put a hand on Arlo's back, saying, "I'll go talk to her, Arlo, don't worry about it."

Arlo didn't look their way but muttered, "I'm sorry everyone."

Scarlet and Sully and Cheyenne and Byron all muttered things like no need to apologize and don't worry about it, and Arlo left the kitchen in Lily's wake.

Scarlet set her stack down, saying, "Wow, that was so weird. I've never seen them talk like that before."

Sully said, "Lily has always been sort of wound up tight, you know."

Byron said, "Yeah, but we're on vacation. She should relax now."

Cheyenne said, "I'm so glad that we've been"—she looked up realizing Carla was still there then continued anyway—"what *we've* been doing on the yacht has been kept on the down low, you know?"

Sully agreed with Cheyenne. "They'd have *never* been able to handle it."

Carla chuckled as Byron returned from the kitchen closet with a broom and a dustpan,. She said, "Don't be so sure about that."

Cheyenne wrinkled her nose. "What do you mean?"

Carla chuckled again and waved it off, saying, "Never mind." Then she took Byron's arm. "Leave the sweeping, buddy. There's a shop vac. Come help me bring it in. It'll just take a few seconds."

Byron said, “What’s a shop vac?”

Carla took Byron’s hand, winking at Cheyenne as they passed saying, “A wet dry vac. Guess *your* sorority never had a decent party.”

“I know what a wet dry vac is,” Byron muttered as Carla led him out to the side deck.

Cheyenne chuckled then when Carla and Byron were gone. “I forgot she was here. Shit, I almost said too much.”

Sully came over, realizing now there was a reason he’d been summoned to the kitchen. “What’s going on?”

Scarlet and Cheyenne stared at him, Sully looking from one to the other. “What is it? What’s going on?”

Cheyenne said, “Sully, have a seat...”

* * *

The breeze from the sea was cooler at night and Byron shuddered as a chill passed through him—but Carla’s hand was warm. There was something he really liked about holding her hand. Right in front of Chey, like it was no big deal. Which was great, because he really enjoyed affection with Carla. She swung their arms between them, doing it playfully, making him laugh. When she let his hand go, he wiped his palm on his short leg. Carla asked him if he thought she had the cooties.

“No,” he said. “I’m all clammy. I ate too much dinner.”

“You’re not stuffed, are you?”

“Kind of,” he said. “Aren’t you?”

“Stuffed? Not yet.”

He lowered his brow, thinking about it, seeing it was a pretty obvious come on, but he didn't know what she meant. It reminded him of something else however, and he worried about it enough he thought it might be a good time to talk about it. They trotted down the steps together to the deck below, heading into the hallway that ran between all the lower bedroom suites.

He said, “Hey, wait up a second,” reaching out to touch Carla's elbow.

She turned, looking sly. “Don't you dare ask me for a quickie.”

“What,” he said, shocked, bordering on offended. “I wouldn't...”

“I know you wouldn't, Byron,” she said. “You're a good guy. You're not like that at all. Which is exactly why I find it so funny to get you going.”

“Well, ha-ha,” he said. “I hope you're enjoying yourself.”

“I kind of am,” she said, crossing her arms, squashing her generous bosom against the fabric of her top. “What's the hold up for?”

“Oh,” he said, feeling self-conscious about the whole thing now. “It's nothing, it's just...” He looked at his own hands which were twisting and gesturing with great discomfort, looking like two ducks shot in the sky by hunters and fluttering to the ground. He closed them in fists and put them against his sides. “It's just...”

“Go ahead and tell me,” she said, “after what we've done, what's got you so *verklemt*?”

Byron sighed, looking around to confirm they were alone. He said, “Should anything ever again happen—”

“With you and me?” She wagged her manicured finger in between the two of them.

“Yeah,” he said. “Between you and me.”

“Go on...”

“If anything happens between us again, and say someone else is there...”

“Kinky.”

“It *is* kinky, and I’m not saying it’s going to happen, I just mean...”

“I *know* you’re not saying it’s gonna happen, just get to the point already.”

“Okay, if something looks like it were to happen...”

“Between us?”

“Between us,” he said again, now looking at her face. She looked like she could handle anything he was going to say and it gave him confidence. “If anything were to happen between us again and maybe somebody made some implication about us already having been together...”

“You and I.”

“About you and I being together...”

Carla rolled her head back on her neck. “*Please* get to the point.”

He sighed again and rubbed his head. “Would you just play along?”

“I *am* playing along.”

“No, in this scenario I’m creating. I’m asking if you would play along if someone suggested that we’ve been together and done things together that you would just nod and smile and not disagree.”

“But we *were* together. What are you talking about?”

“If someone...”

“Chey?”

“Not Chey, somebody else.”

She snapped her fingers. “Oh. Sully.”

“For example,” he said. Though that *was* exactly who he was talking about.

Carla wagged her palms toward him, narrowing her eyes like she didn’t wanna hear any more lies. She said, “No-no. It’s Sully. You told Sully we did something crazy that we didn’t do, and you’re worried I’m going to out you as a liar.”

“I’m not a liar,” he said.

She smiled. “Yeah, you are. I know exactly what I’m talking about.”

He hissed, “Did he talk to you already?”

She smiled wider. “See? That’s it exactly. No, he didn’t talk to me, I just know what *guys* are like. Especially guys like you.” She got closer, put her fingertips against his chest and let them drag down in light lines. His skin went to goosebumps.

“Anyway, so *would* you?” he said, a hint of anger in his voice. Mad that he had to ask this, mad that he lied to Sully in the first place, and mad that Carla was so all-seeing.

She said, “What did we not do, that you want me to say we did?”

“Whatever he comes up with.”

“Byron,” she said, chiding him. “Whatever Sully says, it’s going to be something *you* told him. So you tell me now. Tell me what we did that we didn’t actually do.” She wriggled in place, getting her posture straight. “I need to be prepared.”

Byron waffled, so insecure about saying out loud the name of the sex act.

Carla said, “What, is it *so* shocking that I just can’t handle it? Am I going to run screaming from the room?”

“I can’t picture that.”

“Yet you pictured something else. So come on and tell me what was it you pictured us doing that we just didn’t get around to.”

“Well... it’s just that Sully asked me this specifically and it was so obvious I couldn’t believe I hadn’t thought of it myself and for whatever reason...”
He threw up his hands, embarrassed by the whole thing.

“What’s so obvious? We had sex, we had lots of fun.” She put her hands on her hips. “You had fun, didn’t you?”

“Of course I did.”

Her eyes went sleepy. “You *were* a little preoccupied.”

“There was a lot going on that night, Carla.”

“There sure was. Do you really think there’s gonna be another time between us?”

“I didn’t say that.”

“Do you want to?”

He felt stupid now. “I mean, yeah, but I mean...”

“Did you ask Chey?”

“We haven’t really talked about it yet. I mean, I don’t know what we’re gonna do now...”

Carla's lips thinned, nodding, brain going a million miles an hour. Then she guessed in a low husky voice, "Was it anal?"

"No, it wasn't anal," he muttered.

Carla snapped her fingers again, like something just occurred to her, and before she could say anything else that would embarrass him, Byron closed his hand around her small finger-snapping fist. She laughed. He said, "Never mind. It's not going to happen anyway, this *next* time."

"You never know unless you try..."

He felt her breath on his skin, and his goosebumps tightened. He said, "I mean we're never gonna be in this situation where Sully's there with us."

"You don't see me inviting Sully into my bedroom?"

"You wouldn't?"

"That's my business, buddy. What kind of girl do you think I am?"

"Oh, I didn't mean to imply—"

She kissed the top of his hand and it silenced him. And then, now very close to him, she whispered, "Did you tell Sully you fucked my tits?"

He snatched his hand away from her like she was some treacherous Casanova and he was a Victorian virgin. She laughed at him and clapped her hands quietly. "That was it, wasn't it?"

Now he laughed too, and palmed his forehead. At least she saw the humor in it. He said, "Yeah, maybe I said that. Okay?"

"Of course you said that. Do you know what's funny? I don't know why *I* didn't think of doing it."

"Why would *you* think of it?"

“You think I don’t like that? I like that.”

“You do?”

“Sure I do. And you know what else?”

“What?”

“I know you’re not a liar.”

“I’m not.”

“I’m not a liar, either.”

“You’re not?”

Carla dipped her chin and looked aside. “No, I am. Actually I lie quite a lot. But listen... *You’re* not. We’re talking about you.” She crossed her arms and studied him. “This has really been bugging you.”

He nodded, chewing his cheek. “Is that weird?”

“No,” she said. “That’s you. That’s Byron. That’s why people like you. People like me because I lie, people like you because you don’t lie. That’s your game. So I got a solution for you...”

“What’s that?”

She stepped very close to him, smiling, looking in his eyes. Her arms went around his waist and her body pressed against his. She said, “There’s a bedroom door right here, Byron.” She wagged her platinum blond head to the side, the hallway lanterns twinkling in her beautiful, icy eyes. “Come in with me. End the lie. Come in and titty fuck me. I would love that. I *want* it. Let’s go do it and then you can tell Sully every little detail with a clear conscience.”

“I wouldn’t do that, Carla. I wouldn’t—”

“Sully my reputation? Please. You don’t wanna be a liar, do you?”

“Carla, I *can’t*.”

“You *can’t*? Come on now, Byron,” she said, pulling him closer to the bedroom door, and her hand slipping along the front of his shorts and grabbing between his legs. She made a small sound of comical shock and said, “That’s what I like most about you, Byron. You’re *always* hard.”

CHAPTER 7

Lily had a head-start but Arlo knew where she was headed. He found her in their bedroom suite, the lights off except for the bedside table lamps. The room appeared empty, but he called out her name and heard movement in the bathroom. The lights were off in there, too. “Lily,” he said again, closing the door behind him, strolling into their room with his hands in the pockets of his shorts. “Come out here, please. We need to talk.”

From the bathroom came a mumbled “no.” Lily’s tone was firm yet soft and delicate, just like his wife. He sighed, tugging on his short legs as he sat down on the side of the bed, facing the bathroom. From the shaded cone of light cast from the table lamps he could see her in there, bare feet, wearing her pink unicorn PJs. He put out a hand, laid one palm over the other and began pushing downward on the palm to flexes the muscles on the inside of his forearm. He switched hands and did the same with the other. “Lily, we have to talk.”

Lily muttered, “Go away.”

Now he linked his fingers together, turned his joined hands inside facing out, palms toward Lily, stretching his arms again and cracking his knuckles.

He took on the tone of a patient but aggrieved parent, his tone steady and armored against refusal. “Let’s go, please, Lily.”

Lily sighed and clucked her tongue; he heard the quiet click of her ankle joint as she shifted from one foot to the other and made a reluctant path to the doorway. She stopped there. “I don’t *wanna* talk,” she said.

Arlo checked his watch. “It’s far too early for bedtime, little girl.”

“I was going to read first.”

“You can read if you choose—once we’ve talked.”

“I don’t want to talk,” she said, childish and petulant.

“Are you proud of your outburst?”

Lily pouted and looked away.

He said, “I wasn’t proud of it. I was embarrassed. Do you know what that looks like to everyone?”

“I don’t care,” she said.

“You do care, Lily. You can act like a baby all you want, you can stand there and tell me you don’t care. I don’t believe it for one second. *You* don’t believe it and *I* don’t believe it, and where does that leave us? It leaves a standing here with your selfish little lie hanging in the air like a noxious fart.”

A small smile flashed on Lily’s face and she leaned closer to the door frame, resting her forehead on it and drawing lines on the mahogany trim with the tip of her index finger.

“You’re stinking up our bedroom with your lying farts.”

She snickered.

“I’m angry at you, though, you know?”

She nodded and looked down.

“I’m very angry with you. That was such a childish thing to do. You embarrassed me, but worse, you embarrassed yourself. In front of our friends. What were you thinking?”

Now her lips blubbered, and she scowled at him. “What was *I* thinking? What were *you* thinking? How about you? Bringing him here. Bringing him all the way here.”

“Don’t tell me you didn’t know.”

“I *didn’t* know,” she said.

“You did, Lily. You knew. You knew and you hate yourself for knowing and to make yourself feel better you threw a ridiculous tantrum in the kitchen. You smashed that plate. They had to go get a Shop Vac to clean it up.”

“So?”

He grumbled and shook his head. “That’s it, Lily,” he said, stern, the attenuated tendril of his patience wiggling and waving, unable to support the weight of his anger. “Come. Here.”

“Why?”

“Don’t say why, Lily. When I ask you to do something, you do it. And you *know* why.”

She sighed again, this time rolling her head around, wanting to object and complain more but knowing it would only make her punishment worse.

“Come stand by me,” he said, patting his right knee. “What do you say?” he asked her as she complied.

She muttered, "I'm sorry."

"Sorry for what?"

"I'm sorry I broke a plate."

"And...?"

"Embarrassing you."

"Pull your bottoms down."

Lily hesitated, her lips wriggling as her brain struggled to form a reasonable protest. But she knew there was none, and her hands complied, coming to her sides, slipping thumbs under the waistband and pushing down her unicorn PJ pants just below her bottom.

He said, "Your underwear, too."

Lily blubbered. "*A-and* my underwear?"

"I'm very cross with you, little lady."

"I said I was sorry, Daddy."

"Underwear. Now." He snapped his fingers and jabbed the index between her legs.

Lily repeated the same action, slipping her thumbs under her plain petite cotton underwear and lowering it to expose her bottom.

Arlo patted his lap. "Put your tummy down here."

Lily stooped as if she would pray, hooking her elbows on the opposite side of his lap and pulling herself forward to lay her tummy over the top of his thighs.

"That's a good girl," he said. "You have to remember your place."

She said, “I can still be mad at you, Daddy.”

“There are better ways of expressing it, Lily, wouldn’t you agree?”

She opened her mouth to answer, but he brought the flat of his palm down across her bared ass cheeks in a loud smack. Lily yelped and kicked her legs. “Stay still,” he reminded her.

“That hurt, Daddy.”

“It’s supposed to hurt,” he said and brought his hand down again in quick succession three times—crack, crack, crack. Lily howled and kicked her feet again and he used his free hand to steady her convulsing body on his lap. “I’m not done with you,” he told her.

“Okay-okay,” she said. “I know, I know.”

“What do you know?”

“I was bad.”

“You were,” he said, let a bit of silence hang and then brought his hand down in a hard crash on her pale, rosy bottom, blooming with reddish handprints.

“Okay, Daddy,” she said, “ow, okay,” twisting her arms behind her and blocking her blushing bottom with her hands.

“Take your hands away, Lily.”

Lily breathed heavy through her mouth for a second then obeyed, removing her hands and letting them fall to the floor. “I’m sorry,” she said, defeated.

“I know you are, Pet,” he said, and now instead of giving her one more good resounding spank, he caressed and coddled her bottom, just for a

moment before tugging up her underwear. “Okay,” he said, “you can get off now.”

Lily slunk away, sniffing, pulling up her PJ bottoms, doing a little dance to get them seated properly. Arlo folded his arms and regarded her. She was beautiful; eyes bright, expression twisted somewhere between happiness and supplication. She wiped her nose, looking around for an awkward moment before crossing one arm over her tummy and holding the opposite elbow.

“If you have a grievance, Lily, it’s now in the privacy of our bedroom you can tell me about it.”

“You know what it is.”

“I’d like you, little lady, to put it into big people words.”

“I trusted you,” she said.

“You trusted me and *what?*”

“You let him in our bedroom.”

“Lily, we talked about this,” he said, rubbing his thighs then plucking a stray pink cotton thread from her new underwear that had attached to his shorts. He flicked it away. “Would you prefer the alternative?”

She didn’t answer, only showed him a sulky expression.

“Well, *would* you?”

When she still didn’t answer, he described it for her in clearer terms. “Do you know what they’re doing? We talked about it.” He didn’t let her answer, continuing, “You told me how afraid you were. And I did everything I could to make it better. Would you *prefer* an orgy?” He clapped his hands loud and Lily jumped, her eyes darting to his. “Well, would you?”

“No,” she said.

“Then you *don’t* trust me...”

“I don’t like *him*. I don’t like *him* at all.”

“Perhaps you could’ve been clearer with me. I know you know it was a possibility. It’s not a complete surprise though you act it’s like one. The truth is a night with *him* and all the things *he* likes to do is better than a night with our friends doing those dirty things. Are you one of *those* girls, Lily? Are you going to walk around here naked, are you gonna play *games*? Is that what you want? Did you want to play a game with Cody’s penis?”

“No.”

“With Philippe’s penis?”

She looked away. He clapped his hands again, and she looked at him.

“Is that what you wanted?”

She shouted, “No!”

“Don’t be a baby. You take your lumps. And what you definitely don’t do is embarrass me and embarrass yourself and embarrass our marriage in front of our friends by airing out our grievances in public.”

Lily stood there now with her chin dimpled and tucked down to her collar, her arms hanging loose and apish at her slim sides.

“Do I need to spank you again?”

“No,” she said, clear and defiant.

“Are you sure? Because I don’t think I’ve got through to you.”

“You did, Daddy.”

He pointed toward the bedroom door. “Should I go and get him right now?”

She said, “Who?” inquisitive but guarded, knowing who he implied, disbelieving and frightful.

“Him.”

When she spoke his name, it was uttered in a fearful, tight, chest-constricted whisper. “Mr. Graves.”

“Mr. Graves, Lily. You don’t think he’s still here?”

“I wish he’d go home,” she said.

“That’s where you like him? Do you like him at home?”

“I *hate* him. I *hate* him *everywhere*.”

“But perhaps if you were a better girl...”

“I didn’t do anything wrong,” she said.

“Didn’t he *prove* you did? . . . He *has* authority, you know. He has a lot of authority...”

“I *know*,” she said, beating her fists against his thighs, dipping at the knees and bouncing. “Please—I know, I know, I *know*...”

“He could put you in prison. How about that? If you comply, he won’t. Life is *that* way, Lily. Do you think life’s easy? Do you think you get everything you want? Do you think that’s what the grown-up world is like? How about me? Do you think I go to work every day and I just can’t wait to hang around with that asshole Shellenberger talking shit and acting like a big shot when I know deep down, deep in my heart”—he jabbed a thumb against his chest—“I can out-cook that guy, I can out-think him, build a better menu, I’m a better business person, and yet *he’s* the one, he’s the one with his foot

on my neck, and that's what life is *like*, Lily. Life is like that. You have a foot on your neck from the moment you take your first breath until when you die. There's only one time when you don't... And when is that?"

"When..." Her cute mouth twisted to the side.

"When?"

Lily said, "When my Daddy protects me."

"And you don't trust me?"

"I didn't mean it."

"Tell me now, Lily. Should I tell Mr. Graves to go? Should I let him go back to his office in Washington, sit in his cubicle, crank out the numbers... Can you picture him with his little green visor tap-tap-tapping away on his big-button calculator, looking for where this poor little New York City girl made a mistake—because he *knows* you did. And you think *I'll* punish you? If you think my punishments are harsh, the things he'll do to you Lily...? Ho boy..."

"Ho boy," she repeated.

"But you can't get away, you can't run fast enough. There's nowhere, *nowhere* on the whole earth his tentacles can't reach. So, you do what you can to make him happy. You open yourself up to him..."

"I *hate* that. I *hate* it when he does that."

"Be my guest, then," he said, "just go out the bedroom suite door, why don't you take off your PJs, take off your little pink bottoms and strut around up there like Cheyenne does? Or Scarlet even. At least Carla has the decency to keep her clothes on most of the time. What, do you wanna be like that? Do you want to lie with those men who are our friends?"

“No,” she said, her voice cracking.

“I’m going to go get him.”

Her eyes widened. “Don’t...”

“He came all this way for you, Lily. He came all this way. He has authority. I do what I can to keep him back, but there’s only so much I can do. We want a future together. You have your business and you know I want to start mine. Carla said she could help.”

Lily nodded

“So, which is it? Cody or Mr. Graves?”

Lily sighed and hung her head again, lumbered to the bed like her light body weighed a thousand pounds, climbed up onto the mattress and collapsed in the pillows, curling up on her side and plugging her thumb into her mouth.

Arlo took her wrist and guided out her thumb. “Don’t do that,” he said.

She pouted.

“Who should I go and get, Lily?”

Lily’s lips pooched out, her eyes staring to the bathroom, blinking. “Mr. Graves,” she said.

CHAPTER 8

B yron didn't know how Carla got the door open without him noticing, but she did, pressing forward now, breasts first, backing him into the open room.

“Carla, what are you doing?”

“You make it sound like I’m seducing you,” she said.

“You are.”

She closed the door and put her back against it, blocking his only escape.

They were in was a bedroom suite across the hall from Philippe’s. No one stayed in it, the room empty and the bed made, the lights off. Weak Caribbean dusk glowered through the windows in burned orange.

She smiled, licking her lower lip, and his eyes lowered to her nipples pressing out the fabric of her cotton tank top. She wasn’t even wearing a bra.

Cheyenne did not like it when Carla had strutted around the breakfast table in a nightshirt with her breasts free and swinging. She sure wouldn’t like the situation right now. He laughed it off, saying, “What are you gonna do to me?”

“Make you an honest man,” she said.

He showed her his left hand and wiggled his wedding ring finger. “I’m an honest man already, Carla.”

She raised her eyebrows, eyes tired. “If you want to continue being a dirty liar, let that ember burn in the old newspaper pile of your psyche, be my guest. But I know you, Byron,” she said, “and any minute now that ember is going to catch fire and send your tenements up like they were packed full of hoarders.”

Now she began to draw up her top, and he said, “Whoa, whoa, whoa,” putting out his hands and pumping them toward her.

She paused, shirt raised, only her tummy showing. They stared at each other, both of them with small smiles on their face; his reluctant, hers sly.

He broke the quiet. “We don’t have time for this right now.”

“And what would you do if I told you we had time.”

He checked his watch without registering the numbers. “We don’t have time, Carla. We’re supposed to get a vacuum.”

“Like we need a vacuum.”

“You said we did.”

“And you fell for it.”

“So you tricked me to get me down here? You just really enjoy toying with me, don’t you?”

She made a low moan that sounded deep and sexual, and something turned over inside him hearing it. She said, “What if I told you Chey sent me down here?”

He put his hands on his hips. “*Right*. Chey told you to do this. Told Lily to break the plate, too, did she?” Though he was dubious, his brain started to race, trying to make connections that would make it true Carla lured him down here for sex—right out from under his wife’s nose.

Carla said, “I only said *what if* I told you that.”

“You can see my hands on my hips. Is this the posture of a man who would believe you?”

She chuckled, and then pulled up her T-shirt over her head, stripped topless, letting the shirt hang in one hand against her thigh. Her perfect breasts were revealed to him; huge, round, pendulous. The rosy nipples had tightened to buds.

“Holy shit,” he gasped, grimacing at the effort it took to resist grabbing them.

She let the shirt fall to the floor, then caressed her own breasts, looking down and admiring them, thumbing her nipples. “I know you like them, Byron. Put your dick between them, why don’t you?”

“We have to get that vacuum.”

“Like they haven’t swept it up already.”

“You said we had to get it because the plate was wet.”

“Paper towel will take care of that, Byron. You’re so easy to manipulate.”

He rolled his eyes—it took great effort to pull them away from the most amazing set he’d ever seen on a woman. “At least you’re trying to manipulate me into doing something I *want* to do, even though I know I shouldn’t.”

“There’s always a bright side, isn’t there?” She smiled, still caressing her breasts, squashing them together, looking his way, her face and expression *so* alluring. She looked down between his legs and said, “Now it’s your turn.”

“My turn for what?”

“It’s Show And Tell, Byron.” She gyrated her shoulders and made her breasts sway.

He couldn’t take his eyes off them. His hand dropped between his legs and the heel rubbed on the belly of his aching arousal without instruction. His breaths came quicker. “Chey told you to come down with me, did she?”

“She’s not selfish. Do you think your wife is selfish?”

“No,” he said, defensive—but defensive because he wanted to protect his wife from the truth. She *had* been selfish.

“She’s not selfish Byron. . . . Do you think she’s been with Cody?”

“I know she’s been with Cody.”

“I mean since then, since when you watched them in my bedroom.”

“No,” he said, troubled. “Why?”

“Big yacht, you’re not always with her. . . . Shoot, you were gone most of the day today.”

“Cody was with me.”

“Good point. But you *know* what I’m saying.”

“More head games?”

One eyebrow cocked, she said, “Don’t you like head games?”

“What? No...”

“You sure liked head games or first night together.”

“Oh,” he said, chuckling, then repeating and putting in air quotes: *head games*.

“Exactly,” she said, easing off the door and strolling toward him. “Take it out. You make me feel foolish standing here with my top off.”

“*You* did that.”

“You’re making me do it.” She rubbed her hands on his chest and then around his shoulders. “You always think I’m up to something.”

“You usually are.”

“That’s true, but all this talk about head games... you think I’m bending your will, harassing you or something?”

“This *is* sexual harassment right here,” he said, looking down at her, smiling and amused, this beautiful woman with no top caressing his torso.

“You can call HR if you want,” she said, “but I’m not gonna stop.”

“I’m not say no, I’m just saying...”

With her hands on his chest she pushed back from him, looking him up and down. “I know you think I’m up to something. I know you think I’m up to something and you don’t like it, but I can guarantee you’ll like it. Maybe just for once in your life Byron you might accept someone really likes you for who you are.”

He stared at her dumbly, and the smile never left her face. She stooped and picked up her tank top from where she’d dropped it on the floor. He

watched her push her arms through it and pull it over for generous bosom. She pulled the shirt down to shorts, still eyeing him.

He said, “Who says I don’t know that?”

“You’re a bundle anxiety, my friend. You put up shields to protect yourself.”

“I have to.”

“Sometimes those shields block even the good from coming in.”

“You’re the good?”

“You know I am, and you know you want it again.” She levered the door handle like she was ready to leave, but stopped and looked over her shoulder. “Want me to watch you jerk off?” The corner of her plump lips curled in a smirk.

“I’m not gonna jerk off,” he said and Carla laughed and left the room, leaving the door open for him to follow.

He grunted, squatted, mashing his cock, every bit of him thinking of sex with Carla and how bad he wanted it. The things he’d wanted to do but couldn’t because all he could think of was Cheyenne. Remembering then the words Sully had said that he hadn’t believed, that had sounded so stupid. That Carla really wanted him, had fantasized about him. That was bullshit.

She was still up to something...

* * *

Before Arlo left, he’d retrieved her laptop and presented it to her. She clutched it to her chest now, sitting on the bed and waiting. Mr. Graves

would want her to show him the laptop. Mr. Graves would want to know *all* her secrets.

She waited and waited and waited but Arlo didn't return for the longest time. Neither did Mr. Graves. Then, at last, movement on the other side of the door. Lily whimpered in anticipation. It was him; she *knew* it. All the way here. All the way thousands of miles traveling to where she thought he couldn't get her.

The door opened, and the man stepped into her room.

Tall and imposing, no nonsense, horn-rimmed glasses, wearing his plain old-school Brooks Brothers black suit, white shirt, black tie. One hand held the black briefcase she feared. When she saw it she took a deep breath and held it, heart pounding in her temples. Mr. Graves turned to face her.

"Mrs. Lily Dixon," he said, controlled and even, intended to sound blank and without emotion, but the tenor of his voice rich with the implication of condescension.

"Mr. Graves," she said, cordial and formal but her voice tight with fear.

He stood regarding her for a long, uncomfortable moment, getting her squirming and playing with her toes, chewing her cheek.

He said, "I see you have your laptop."

"Yes, sir."

"Should we get to work?"

"I'm *supposed* to be on vacation," she said, looking away from him, her eyes darting around the room. She'd like to pop one of the windows open, scramble out into the ocean and swim to shore and hide. But Arlo was right, Mr. Graves could reach her anywhere she went. Even if she went off-grid

and sold hand-painted landscapes out of a coffee shop in some coconut-milk coffee shop in a forgotten Caribbean village she knew Mr. Graves would show up one day.

“You don’t have a desk.” When she shook her head no, he said, “We’ll work on the bed. Lay your laptop down.”

She complied, setting the laptop down on the bed and sliding it away from her toward Mr. Graves. He hummed in his throat that tune she hated to hear, Wagner, coming closer, sitting on the edge of the bed. She relaxed a little when he set his briefcase down on the floor where she couldn’t see it.

“Open the laptop, please. Bring me up your latest entries.”

She swiveled the laptop toward herself, opened it and typed away, getting access, opening up her accounting software and turning it back so he could see. He pushed his glasses up the bridge of his nose and looked at the screen, tapped the touchpad, scrolled, checking all her entries, her scanned receipts, her cash totals, her bank deposits, the money she paid for insurance, health, business, life; FECA payments, the local taxes, state taxes...

Her stomach turned over and an awful feeling of dread seized her heart. Mr. Graves grunted and clucked his tongue at something he found. He brought out his notepad from an inside pocket and produced his fountain pen. He jotted down some notes, shaking his head to himself.

She said, “What is it?”

He turned the laptop toward her. “What do you see there?”

“What?” she said, not knowing what it was he intended, just seeing a column of numbers.

“Third item.”

“Yes, sir?”

“Do you count that as advertising?”

“Well...”

“Well,” he said, mimicking her timid voice. “Mrs. Lily Dixon has not learned her lesson, has she?”

“What’s it supposed to be if it’s not advertising?” she whined.

“You told me you had your books under control.”

Even in her PJs she felt naked before him. Naked, exposed, violated. He had so much power, so much authority, a rampant bureaucratic agent of the regime wielding the power of the Federal Government against a citizen. But there was nothing she could do.

“They *are* under control,” she said, on the verge of tears. “That *is* advertising— how is that *not* advertising?”

He shook his head from side to side, grim, showing her that look that said This is going to hurt me more than it hurts you. “I’m afraid, Mrs. Dixon, that this has triggered another audit.”

Her shoulders slumped and her spine went to jelly. “Again?” Her voice was a small, gasping whisper.

“I’m afraid so, Mrs. Dixon. The IRS doesn’t like cheats. And when we find them, when we rout them out”—his voice raised and took on the power of a backwoods preacher—“when our hounds roust them from their sneaky fox holes, we chase them down. And then what do we do?”

She muttered, “Y-you have to sh-show them... show them...”

Mr. Graves finished it for her: “Show them who’s boss.”

Now Mr. Graves lifted his briefcase to his lap and lay his big hands on it. “You’re exactly right, Mrs. Dixon.” He thumbed open the briefcase’s latches.

“No, no, oh no,” she said, pleading, “please, no...”

“It’s time for your audit, Mrs. Dixon. Remove your pyjamas, please.”

CHAPTER 9

When Byron returned to the kitchen he found Scarlet and Sully rinsing dishes and loading the dishwasher. Sully spotted him over his shoulder and said, “Didn’t you bring the vacuum?”

“Do you need it?” He moved closer to Cheyenne, angling his head to analyze her expression, but she didn’t make eye contact.

Sully said, “No, we swept it up.”

Cheyenne said, “Where’s Carla?”

Byron said, “She went out to the back deck to sit with Cody. Why did you sent me to go get the vacuum?”

Cheyenne kept rinsing and loading, not looking. “I *didn’t* send you,” she said, dishes clinking and rattling.

He studied her for any tic, any giveaway she’d orchestrated his trip down to the bedroom suites with Carla. Cheyenne gave nothing away. So much swam in his head right now. Did Chey send him with Carla because she wanted him to have a fling; did Carla really tell Scarlet she had a thing for good ole Byron; and another one, a little jab of renewed jealousy after so

much had gone right: did Chey do anything with Cody since he'd watched them together in Carla's suite?

He shook his head, cleared his throat. "So, anyway, what's going on up here?"

"Dishes," Sully said.

Cheyenne said, "You and I are gonna have a little chitchat."

Byron folded his arms. "Are we really?"

Sully dried his hands on a towel, coming over, saying, "Buddy, you have to get a load of this..."

"Of what?"

Cheyenne blasted a dish with hot water, stopping Sully, saying, "Wait until Scarlet gets back."

Sully rolled his eyes and got back to work and Byron asked where Scarlet was and Sully said she went downstairs to check on Arlo and Lily, see if they're okay.

Byron said, "Just tell what's going on. Why do we have to chitchat?"

Sully looked towards Cheyenne, saying to Byron, "The girls have got some crazy story for you."

Cheyenne shot him a dirty look. "It's *not* crazy."

Sully tossed the tea towel onto the counter, held open the dishwasher drawer for Cheyenne to load the last of the plates, then closed it and pushed buttons to get it running. He said, "It's crazy if it's true."

Cheyenne crossed her arms. "It's true."

Byron said, “What’s true?”

Sully started to tell him and Cheyenne said, “I told you, wait for Scarlet.”

Sully said to Byron, “Chey needs back up. That’s how crazy the story is.”

“Back up for what? What’s the story?”

Sully waved the question away, letting Cheyenne get to the pots and pans, leaning his elbows on the counter and saying, “You guys went for a vacuum, you and Carla, but I don’t see a vacuum. What happened?”

“By the time we got down there,” he said, “we figured we didn’t even need one.”

“Really?” Sully said, eyes narrowed and disbelieving, raising an eyebrow. “Guy and a girl leave for a vacuum and don’t come back with one, you know what everybody’s gonna think...”

“Think away,” Byron said, and Cheyenne clucked her tongue and shot Sully a dirty look.

Sully said, “Good thing you guys weren’t gone for long.”

“Long enough,” Byron said, “to miss out on some juicy gossip, apparently.”

Sully said, “They made me sit down before they told me.”

“So this is a big deal?”

“If it’s true,” Sully said.

Cheyenne at the sink said in a raised voice, “It *is* true.”

Byron mouthed to Sully, “What is it?”

Sully checked that Cheyenne’s back was turned and leaned closer to Byron, whispering, “She says Cody and Carla and Philippe are cannibals and they

brought Arlo along to cook us up for them.”

* * *

Lily tossed her pyjama bottoms to the floor and scooted up into the pillows, bringing up her knees and hugging her legs. Naked before Mr. Graves. And Mr. Graves was all business, opening the briefcase lid, running fingers over his instruments of exploration, analysis, and inquisition. She chewed her cheek and watched, powerless before this man who had great federal authority.

She tried one more time to assuage Mr. Graves. “You audited me last month.”

“And you told me your books were in order.”

“Isn’t there something else we can do?”

“There was,” he said, still exploring his investigative armory. “But then you let me down. No worry, though, Mrs. Lily Dixon, social insurance number 174-63-1503, because I knew you would let me down. Women like you always do.”

Why were bureaucrats always so superior and smug? Why did a little bit of power spoil every man on the face of the Earth? She was trapped in this drab Kafka nightmare, like falling into a swimming pool with a ball gown.

Mr. Graves produced the worst of his implements, and she gasped with fright. Mr. Graves ignored her, reaching into the breast pocket of his suit again and this time withdrawing his pen light. “The regime,” Mr. Graves said, “is all-seeing. The regime is—”

“All-knowing,” she finished for him.

“Exactly. There is nowhere we won’t go to find out a citizen’s secrets.”

“D-do you h-have to?”

“Part your knees for me, 174-63-1503.”

In slow and hesitating increments, Lily’s knees parted, the soles of her bare feet touching, letting her knees drop right down to touch the bedding, exposing to Mr. Graves her most sacred feminine space.

Mr. Graves pause for a moment and looked between her legs. “The regime appreciates such flexible citizens.”

The man was disgusting. She wanted to close her thighs again, but she let them stay open, impressing him with her limber legs’ ability to spread wide. Spread wide for his intrusion.

And now he shifted closer, still sitting on the side of the bed. She could see through his suit pants the knob end of his big cock pushing up the crotch. A crab apple shape pressing against gabardine. She said, “The government enjoys its dirty work.”

He studied her with contempt. “You speak the words of a dissident. And you *wonder* why they send me after you.”

“I’m not a dissident,” she said. “I’m a good girl. I’m a really good girl.”

“So you say,” Mr. Graves muttered, clicking his government-issue flashlight on and off. She already knew its brightness, 3000 lumens, ready to spot anything he didn’t like, ready to flood her most sacred pink space with megawatt stadium lighting.

“Lay back for me,” he said, leaning over her. Then he rested the stainless steel speculum on her belly and she jolted. “Stay still, 174-63-1503.”

“It’s cold,” she complained.

“There will be much discomfort. You should prepare yourself.”

“I know,” she said. “I know...”

“If I remember correctly,” he said, “174-63-1503 is much easier to spread when she is warm.”

She whimpered. “Are you going to use... use the machine?”

“You don’t want me to skip it,” he warned.

She shook her head now, dragging her fingertips up and down her lean tummy on either side of the spotless gynaecological instrument.

Now Mr. Graves returned to his briefcase, removed from the foam padding with the inserts cut into it, a small gray metal box with a toggle switch and dials on it like an old stereo tuner from her grandpa’s apartment. He touched her heels, and she scooted her legs straighter to give him space to rest the machine. He unwound the thick black electric cable, stepped off the bed, and plugged it into the wall socket. Then he took a moment to clean his glasses, put them back on. He sat then, and snapped on blue latex gloves. He was humming in his throat again. Wagner.

This detestable man. This gray bureaucrat disguising his contempt for the feminine with a cloak of authority.

With a latex-clad thumb, Mr. Graves touched between her legs. She whimpered, sucked her lower lip into her mouth and bit it. She looked up at the ceiling. He worked between her legs, slipping a finger up and down her slit. He said, “You’re very wet.”

“No, I’m not,” she said.

“Your mind is a dissident, but your body craves the regime’s touch.”

“M-maybe I’m a *little* wet,” she said. “But it has nothing to do with you or your stupid regime.”

“I’m looking now for 174-63-1503’s pink pearl,” he said, nudging a finger pad into her furrowed flesh, divining from her sex folds that swollen part of her, bursting with powerful feelings. When he found it, she emitted a high ghostly sound, and then clamped a hand over her mouth so Mr. Graves wouldn’t hear it. Wouldn’t hear her enjoy it.

Mr. Graves’ gaze focussed between her legs, unhitching from the machine its thin red and black cables and the small rubberized alligator clip attached on the end. He said to her, “What’s the frequency?”

“Ten,” she mewled. “Ten megahertz.”

“Before we begin the inquisition, would you like to bite on my belt?”

She shook her head no, angry. “Just do it already,” she spat.

Mr. Graves finger-flipped the stainless steel toggle switch, and the machine began to hum and vibrate between her parted thighs.

“Oh no,” she gasped, her toes curling, her legs writhing on the bed. And then Mr. Graves turned one of the dials, slow, one megahertz, two, three... Each click of the dial raised the insane vibration and wild electric current through the alligator clip and onto her clitoris. As the jagged rubber teeth bit into her bursting, succulent sex bulb, humming and throbbing, her toes tightened further and her legs kicked and writhed as intense pleasure ripped through her like a tropical thunderstorm. She gasped and panted and squeaked, holding back as much sound as she could, hands turning to fists and drumming on her hipbones as she struggled to fight back a huge orgasm.

She wouldn't orgasm for the government. She wouldn't, she wouldn't, she wouldn't. Not anymore.

But now with the machine running, its internal electric dynamo purring like a mean old house cat, he removed one more of his instruments from his briefcase, and presented it so she could see. A huge, translucent gummy-blue dildo studded with smooth round bumps.

"Oh no," she said. "Not that one."

Mr. Graves nodded.

"It's so big, and I'm—I'm so *little* down there."

"Yes, 174-63-1503. If I'm to investigate, if I'm to know your deepest secrets, I must touch your deepest hidden spaces. . . . Now, a formality before we begin..."

He removed his phone from his pocket, lay the huge blue dildo on her tummy, right next to his evil speculum, and put a knee on the bed, looking to get between her legs. She gulped. It was hard to swallow. The pleasure thrumming through her made consciousness hard to get a grip on. Mr. Graves took a picture of her lady parts with the alligator clamp biting on her clitoris, and she complained through the sex fog. "Hey!"

"This is for business documentation, 174-63-1503."

"Who's going to see those pictures?"

"All the agents back at the office."

"Oh my gosh," she cried, her head falling back into the pillows, rolling from side to side as a trembling orgasm leaked from her pussy into her body, getting her thighs shaking, only threatening a huger orgasm to come. Maybe one she couldn't contain.

Mr. Graves took more and more pictures of her pussy. Holding her labia apart, pulling down on her yoke, tapping on the rubberized clamp on her clitoris. Each time he touched her, and she heard the click of his phone's camera, crazy after-orgasm shocks ricocheted through her—and when they did, they triggered a whole new orgasm. Her eyes teared, and she formed fists so hard her hands shook.

Then he put away his phone, telling her now. “I think I’m ready to begin.”

“Be-begin?”

He lifted the blue dildo, wagged it at her, its massive bulk bowing up and down as the huge fake cock head bobbed before her eyes. “This is only the beginning. I’m going to make you pay, Lily.”

“No, no,” she cried, “I can’t take it anymore!”

Someone knocked on their door.

CHAPTER 10

When no one answered, she knocked again. She'd heard raised voices; heard Arlo's voice, deep and sanctimonious, then Lily's, shrill and pleading.

This time when she knocked, Scarlet said, "I know you guys are in there. Is everything okay?"

Then, at last, Lily's voice: "Yeah, we're good. Don't come in, okay?"

Scarlet tested the door lever and found it locked. "Are you coming back out? We want to see you guys. Do you want to play a game?"

"Okay," Lily said, voice tight but trying to sound cheery. "We're going to be just a little bit." Then the sound of a choked back laugh she swore was Arlo.

"We're almost done the dishes. Chey opened another bottle of that Chardonnay you like, Lily. Promise me you're coming up to play cards."

"I promise, Scarlet," Lily said in a light, almost condescending, singsong.

"You better," Scarlet said, crossing her arms, lingering at the door, waiting to hear what they might say when she was gone. But they were quiet now.

* * *

Arlo held both hands over his mouth and his face, knowing he had gone beet red from stifling laughter. Lily batted his shoulder, saying, “Mr. Graves doesn’t laugh.”

“Sorry,” he said, trying to compose himself.

She said, “Ever. He doesn’t *ever* laugh.” Now she disconnected the alligator clamp from between her legs, wincing as it came away and the thrum of the current disconnected from her clitoris.

“Mr. Graves is sorry,” he said. Adding, “174-63-1503.”

“Yeah, well, Mr. Graves better be gone after I count to ten.”

“Twenty,” he said.

Lily—now in her surly mood—tossed herself over on the bed, naked, going onto her front, pulling pillows over her head, and counting down into them, starting at fifteen; a compromise.

Arlo jumped back, unplugged his homemade e-stim machine, gathered all his instruments into his briefcase, ran to the closet and shoved it in there. Next was the suit, which he bolted off, crumpled and tossed into the closet on top of the briefcase. Shirt and tie were next, standing there with no pants, his erection upright and wagging side to side in front of him.

Lily had sped up the count, and he called her on it. She slowed a little, kicking her legs up and down, her countdown muffled under the pillow fort surrounding her head. He slid the closet closed as she counted one and leapt around. He’d had no time to pull on his boxer shorts and she caught him standing there naked.

She looked shocked, putting up a hand to block her view of his erect penis, saying in a shocked gasp, “Oh Daddy!”

“I’m so sorry, sugarplum,” he said, coming to the bed as Lily hid her face under the pillows again. “Where are you PJs? Why were you sleeping with nothing on?” He smiled at her antics, running a hand up her bare back.

She turned to face him, her sweet face peeking out from the shade of the pillows. “I’m mad at you,” she said; not his babygirl, and not the tormented subjugate of the mean bureaucrat known as Mr. Graves, nor any of the other characters they liked to role-play. Just Lily.

“And I’m mad at you,” he said.

“*Me?*” She smiled. “*Why?*”

“I’ve never seen you brattier in my whole life.”

She chuckled and snuggled up against him, kissing his chest, nibbling on his nipple until he complained and then hiding her face in his collar while he rubbed her back. His hand went lower and patted her naked bottom, still blushing from his spanking.

He said, “Mr. Graves doesn’t ever laugh.”

“Never,” she said, her whisper soughing against his neck.

“I couldn’t remember if I locked the door, and then I pictured what Scarlet would see if she came in.”

Lily chuckled too, picturing it: her naked, a machine with wires clamped on her privates, Arlo wearing a suit, a briefcase full of sex-toys—he’d removed the most vulgar for air travel, then had to stop in the town of Cruz Bay on the island, taking a detour on the cab ride from the airport to the yacht. There was a sex shop in Cruz Bay, and he’d done his best to replace his

wife's favorite items he'd left behind so airport security wouldn't pull them out one by one and ask him what it was. All that trouble, then to have their secret sex-life blown by Scarlet opening the door? How could he not laugh?

"You wrecked it, though."

"I'm sorry, little baby. It was Scarlet that wrecked it, not me."

"You have to make it up to me."

"You know I will," he said, caressing a slender arm, cupping her dainty elbow. "What can I do for you?"

"You know the things I like. I don't want to tell you. I want you to know."

In her voice he could hear the rising whiny tone of his babygirl. He said, "I work all day to send you to school, to buy you pretty dresses, to send you to ballet and jazz and tap. Your cheerleader uniform cost me almost five-hundred dollars..."

"So?" She squirmed against him, responding to his patronly diatribe with arousal.

"*So?* You say *So?* The least you could do is tell me what you want, little lady."

She grunted and squirmed away from him, her face twisted in the cutest scowl. She grumbled, "Your thing is all big and weird. Why is it like that?" She sneered like she was disgusted, reaching to touch the small of her back and her waist where his penis had been poking her. "Ew," she complained, rubbing her semen-slippery fingertips together. "Gross, Daddy, there's stuff coming out of it."

He got to his knees, laughing, warning her: "We don't do Daddy sex, Lily. You know that."

She stayed in character, tempting him. “That machine got me feeling so weird, Daddy.”

He warned her again: “Lily...”

“Right here,” she said, touching the flat below her tummy, her eyes staying on his eyes, getting his heart racing. “And maybe a little lower...”

Now her fingers traced down over her shaved mound and into the sopping pink cleft of her hot sex.

He bit his knuckle at her ability to drive him out of his mind. But rules were rules, and he said a firm and permanent no to Daddy sex. He leapt forward and began tickling her, his cock a long stiff thing nodding up and down and slinging more slippery “stuff.”

Lily squealed and abandoned her sex talk, but staying a babygirl and kicking her legs. Then: his insistent tickling brought from Lily the tiniest, quietest little toot.

They both went dead quiet, him with his clawed hands still on his wife’s ribs. Lily’s eyes were wide, her lips sucked into her mouth. He said, “What do you say, Lily?”

She whispered, “Excuse me.”

He brought his hands to his lap and sighed. “Lily... You know what this means.”

She pouted. “No, Daddy. I’m a big girl. I am, I really am.”

He stood, shaking his head, pursing his lips. “We’re going up to play cards with our friends and I don’t want any accidents.”

Lily giggled and bit her lower lip, cheeks blushing with excitement. “Daddy, I’m a big girl.”

He ignored her protesting, going into the dark of their bathroom and rustling through the Chelsea Pharmacy shopping bags. Another stop they'd made on their journey from the airport to the yacht. He reached in, plucked open the box, and produced a diaper for Lily.

* * *

First thing Byron said when Scarlet came up from the deck below was, "Great, now you guys can tell me what the fuck is going on."

Sully shot him a serious look and said, "Byron, I *told* you: they're cannibals. We have to find a way off this ship before Arlo puts us in a really big soup pot."

Byron told him to stick it.

Scarlet joined them, looking at her husband like he was a psycho. "What the fuck are you talking about?"

Sully laughed, then bumped her shoulder with his shoulder. Cheyenne came in to the clutch, saying, "Everything okay down there?"

"I think so," Scarlet said. "They're either arguing or..."

"Fighting or fucking," Sully said.

Scarlet showed him a dirty look again. Sully held up his hands in surrender. "Too much wine," he said.

Cheyenne was concerned about Lily and Arlo. "They were fighting?"

Scarlet shrugged. "Maybe. I don't know. It didn't sound good, but when I asked them if they were coming down Lily said they were and she sounded really chipper."

“So, anyway,” Byron said. “The chit-chat. I’ve been waiting because Chey wouldn’t tell me anything until you got here.”

“Oh,” Scarlet said. Then gestured for Chey to step in. “Go ahead, tell him.”

Chey said, “You tell him.”

Scarlet rubbed her forehead like she had a headache. “Okay, this was Chey’s thought—”

“*I* thought of it, and I’m right.”

Scarlet looked at Chey sideways, continuing, “See, she talked to Philippe when we got here—Byron, that night with the toilet tube...”

“I remember.”

“And Philippe had said he and Paloma split up, but he wanted to get back together...”

Sully said, “Byron’s not sitting down. You guys made me sit down.”

Cheyenne jabbed through the middle of the group and punched Sully’s shoulder. Sully chuckled to himself, rubbing where he’d been thumped.

“Please, just get to the point,” Byron said.

Scarlet said, “The point is, Chey doesn’t think any of them are being honest.”

“Okay. And?”

“Look, Chey said she didn’t think that Paloma and Philippe looked like they’d spent that much time apart when they were reunited on the boat this afternoon.”

“Seemed okay to me,” Byron said, then looked to Cheyenne. “What makes you say that?”

“It just didn’t seem right.”

“How?”

“I don’t know, okay? It just didn’t seem right. Girls see things different, Byron.”

Scarlet said, “I missed the reunion.”

Chey said, “But you trust my opinion, right?”

“Uh, yeah.”

“What do you mean, ‘uh,’ Scarlet?”

“Nothing,” she said, reassuring her. “I trust your opinion.”

Byron said, “So what does that matter, anyhow?”

Chey turned to him, holding his forearms. “Think about it, baby. Cody rents this big yacht, cuts us all a break on the price, brings us out here to no-man’s-land, a private do-what-you-want-space...”

“We paid our share, Chey.”

She rolled her eyes. “You said yourself, not the full amount.”

“So?”

Sully said, “Cannibals, Byron,” and Cheyenne shot him a look like she’d swat him again.

Scarlet said, “Chey thinks they brought us out here...”

Footsteps stopped her mid-sentence, and she looked to the side. Cheyenne let his arms go.

Paloma entered the kitchen, coming in from the back deck, her dress a brilliant yellow against her tanned skin. Behind her the others were following, Philippe and Cody talking and laughing, Carla smiling knowingly, her eyes on Byron's. He looked away.

"Look how clean you make it," Paloma crooned, setting down her empty wine glass. She stood taller than Chey and Scarlet, wearing low heels while the girls wore sandals. "You're so wonderful."

"Thanks," Sully said, like he was smitten, a man under a charm spell.

Chey said, "What are you guys doing in here? We were about to come out."

Paloma said, "We'll sit, we'll sit and talk. Maybe play some games. But we wanted to talk to you first."

Chey said, "Me?"

Paloma's gaze traveled across all their faces. "No, all of you, of course. Please, come with us..."

She held out a hand for Scarlet and Scarlet took it and Paloma led her away.

Carla held out her hand for Byron and said, "Come on, Byron, we're all going to go down to my suite."

"What for?"

She wove her fingers through his, smiling. "Don't worry. It's not going to hurt."

He swore to fucking god Sully was joking about the cannibal thing, but right now his heart raced and his scalp tightened.

CHAPTER 11

Carla went into their suite first, Cody holding the door for everyone, Carla gesturing for them all to take a seat wherever they could. Sully went with Scarlet to where they'd sat when they watched Cody have sex with Cheyenne. Before they'd got up and joined in with Cody, pleasuring Chey, Sully even putting his cock into Chey's mouth. Cheyenne sat on the edge of the bed and Byron turned back from where he was headed: the chair where he'd sat and watched another man fuck his wife—just the way his wife had wanted him to. He sat at Chey's side, hips and thighs touching, and Chey took his hand, her eyes on the masters of the ceremony: Cody and Carla.

As Cody closed the door and came to stand next to his wife, who leaned on the low table between the two archways that led to their master suite, Byron said, "What is this about? It sounds serious."

Philippe dragged out the chair Byron had sat on and the other matching one, and brought them near the foot of the bed for him and Paloma to sit on, now all of them facing each other in an irregular circle about a dozen feet across.

Carla said, "I bet there's been a lot of chatter today about Paloma showing up."

Byron said, “I’m glad she’s here. I’m happy she came to spend time with us. Is there something I’m missing?” Chey squeezed his hand.

Carla said, “I didn’t think it was you doing the talking, my friend.”

Byron looked to Chey, then past her to Scarlet sitting next to Sully—also holding hands. Scarlet flashed a quick smile, peeking at Chey, one leg crossed over the other, the foot bouncing.

With the room quiet and no one joining in on the conversation, Byron cleared his throat and said, “I guess you guys are getting back together?”

Philippe and Paloma looked at each other, smiling, eyes dreamy. He took her hand. “We are.”

Carla said, “And that’s why she’s here.”

“Right for them to come back together. Like a brand new start. No?”

Chey said, “No,” and Carla looked at Chey, smirking.

“They aren’t apart.”

Paloma said, “No, we were apart. Taking time, as you say.”

“I don’t say that,” Chey said. “This whole thing is some kind of scheme.”

Byron said, “What whole thing?”

Scarlet said, “The trip, the yacht, the—”

“Swinging,” Chey finished.

Cody said, “Now what makes you say that?”

“It’s quiet, it’s intimate, it’s private. You brought us all here for one thing.”

Carla said, “Hey, next time, Chey, we can book a hotel and you can lay by the pool with kids running around and yelling, and a bunch of middle-aged dudes watching you sunbathe. . . . Who doesn’t want privacy?”

“It’s more than that,” Chey said.

Carla chuckled, bowing her head in submission, then sitting back again, flipping her wavy hair back from her face. “You’re not wrong.”

Chey snapped her fingers, then looked over at Scarlet, who nodded.

Byron said to her, “Is this what you were trying to tell me?”

Chey brought his hand into her lap and lay her other hand over it now, too. “All right,” she said to Carla. “Let’s hear it.”

Carla gestured with one hand to Paloma and Philippe, tilting her head.

Philippe took a breath, then looked past Chey to Scarlet and Sully. “Paloma and I are on a break. We broke up, yes, but maybe not in the traditional way. Not in the way you’d expect.”

“Polycule,” Chey said, nodding to herself.

“Yes, you’re not wrong. Paloma and I are on a break because we separated a relationship. We’re not traditional. Don’t think of it as two couples coming together. We were a group of people who were *all* together. Not a collection of couples, you understand? And when we lose one, we lose the whole union.”

Paloma said, “Like a ship broken on the rocks, the cargo spread out at sea. When the daylight comes, we must find one another again.”

“So, wait,” Byron said, squinting, wondering if this was really what Chey had been about to explain to him. He pointed to Paloma and Philippe, saying, “You two *aren’t* a couple. You’re in a group. A poly whatever. And

when someone leaves the group, the poly thingy, the whole shebang goes off kilter, and then you guys act like you're not a couple anymore."

"Because we're not a couple."

Byron rubbed his forehead.

Paloma said, "We don't see ourselves as two. We saw ourselves as more than that."

"But four minus two, or however many you lost from the poly thing—"

"Polycule," Chey said.

"Polycule. Four minus two can't be two? Someone leaves and the rest have to re-evaluate the whole relationship?"

Philippe nodded. "That's it exactly."

"But then... But there's no hardship between you and Paloma, so why can't you just be two?"

"Maybe we can. But we've never been only two. Our relationship with each other works only in frame with others."

Sully said, "So what happened to 'the others?'"

Paloma and Philippe exchanged looks, like it was maybe something they wouldn't want to talk about it. "They separated," Philippe said.

Byron said, "Were they a couple? Were they okay as two?"

"At first," Paloma said.

Byron sighed, rubbed his thigh with the hand Chey didn't hold trapped. "Okay, great, but what does that have to do with us?"

Chey, with firm pronunciation, said aloud, "This is an *audition*."

Carla smiled at Chey, like she appreciated Chey's savvy, then looked up at Cody. She imitated Chey's tone and syncopation: "This is an... opportunity."

Byron looked at Chey's profile, over to Carla staring at Chey. "How?"

"We're building," Philippe said. "We're building a life, we're building a farm, we're building a future."

Carla said, "They're building an opportunity."

Sully said, "What kind of opportunity?"

Cheyenne said, "They want *us*."

Carla shook her head. "It's not nefarious, Chey. I really do see it as an opportunity."

Byron said, "We're building our own house, Chey and I. They're working on it now."

Cody shook his head. "Don't worry about that."

Byron sighed and shook his head like he was disappointed. "I thought we were just having fun. I didn't know this was something more than that."

"It's not," Philippe said and Byron looked over. "It's not—not for you at least. Nothing more than fun."

"What do you mean not for me?" He suffered this jealous stab, like Philippe insinuated they only wanted Cheyenne.

Paloma said, "I'm here because I was told there may be a possibility..."

Byron scowled, still stinging at the suggestion they would take his wife but not him, but now his eyes followed Paloma's gaze across the circle of friends to Sully and Scarlet. Sully's eyes went wide.

Sully sat straighter. “What do you mean? Why are you looking at me?”

Paloma smiled and leaned her head on Philippe’s muscular shoulder. “He told me.”

Scarlet said, “Told you what?”

“It’s okay,” Paloma urged, smiling warm and wide. “He told me everything. I wanted it to happen for him, and he told me it was good.”

Byron said, “You jumped on a plane because these three...”

“You must have been hanging out at the airport with your bags packed,” Cheyenne said.

“I was ready, yes,” Paloma admitted.

“Waiting,” Cheyenne said, “to find out which one of us took the bait.”

Paloma frowned. “How you mean?”

“The audition,” Chey said.

Paloma looked to Philippe and asked him something in Portuguese. Philippe moved his mouth around, trying to explain it. “Audition, like for a part in a movie. She thinks this was a chance to see who would be good in bed.”

“Hey, whoa, no, not like that,” Chey said. “Not who was good in bed, but like, who was a... I don’t know... you know, a *player*.”

Paloma asked Philippe again for clarification, and Philippe said, “Who was, uh... *cool*.”

“Oh, yes, okay, I see,” Paloma said. “No, no, you are all cool.”

“No, like *cool*,” Chey said, “as in who was down for kinky stuff.”

“It’s not just kinky, Cheyenne,” Paloma said. “It’s how we live. It’s how we love.”

Byron looked to Chey and was surprised to see her flummoxed for once.

Philippe said, “And it’s not an *open* audition, Cheyenne, no offense. We’re here, or *I’m* here, was here, for them.” He nudged his chin across the circle, and Byron looked at Sully and Scarlet again. Their eyes had grown wider.

Scarlet said, “*Us?*”

Paloma slinked against Philippe’s arm, holding his hand still. “You had fun last night, yes? I heard many things you do. I heard you get along so well. Philippe, he say such good things.”

Cheyenne chuckled in disbelief, her light body shaking against Byron’s side.

Scarlet said, “Did he really?” She smirked, but her brows were lowered in disbelief, one hand blocking her mouth like she was shy.

Philippe said, “I came to the yacht thinking of you.”

“Of me?”

“Yes,” Paloma said. “He told me. He told me before he come.”

Byron looked to Sully and Scarlet, both of them staring in blank shock. Then they looked at each other, saying nothing, then back to the group.

Scarlet said, “I don’t know what the fuck’s happening here.”

“Nothing, nothing,” Paloma sang in a smooth, placating tone. “Nothing happen.”

Sully said, “I... Okay... And why did *you* come?”

Paloma inclined her head like it should be obvious—and her amused expression, the angle of her long neck... Byron got it before she said it.

“Me, Mr. Sully? Me, I am here for you.”

Sully stared for the longest moment with no reaction, then his shoulders bounced up and down and he laughed in a loud, get-out-of-here sound that got Byron laughing, too. Chey elbowed him.

“Come on,” Sully said. “*What?*”

Scarlet scowled.

Paloma said, “My man,” patting Philippe’s shoulder, “my good, good man, my lover of lovers, he tell me to come. Come and see. Now I am here.”

Scarlet said, “Here for what? Sleeping with my husband?”

Paloma said, “Sleeping with you, Scarlet.”

Sully’s smile faded.

Paloma said, “And you, too, Mr. Sully, who I always think was so funny.”

Scarlet said, “Us?”

Paloma stood, her yellow skirt flashing around her tanned thighs, holding out her hand. “I am more straightforward, maybe than American. But I come this way for you. I come this way, I nap all afternoon, and now I am ready. Ready for you.”

Sully stood and Scarlet pulled him back down by the back of his shirt. They looked at each other, both of them troubled, tongue-tied, not knowing what to say, their mouths attempting to make sounds but just making the odd vowel shape with no sound emitting. Then Scarlet stood, and for a second Byron was sure she was going to stomp out of the room, but instead she

shook her head, eyes narrowed to slits, blinking and blinking as she tried to make sense of the whole thing. Sully popped up to stand with her.

“Yes, yes, yes,” Paloma said, excited, encouraging, crossing the circle and taking Scarlet’s hand. “We have so much fun,” she said, crinkling her nose, “so much fun. I like you very much.”

Sully said, “Uh, wait, like... what? Here in the room. In front of everybody?”

Paloma chuckled and ran a finger down Sully’s chest. “You are the one who is kinky. Now I get it. So kinky.”

Philippe rose and walked past Byron and Chey to stand behind Paloma, resting his hands on her bronzed shoulders. “Not here, buddy. Our suite, your suite. Now, later. Never even, if that’s what you say.”

Paloma made a sound of extreme disappointment. “Oh, no, no, they no say no.” Now she took up Scarlet’s hand and Sully’s hand and led them to the door, Scarlet resistant yet stumbling along, anyway. Cody went ahead and held the door for them to leave.

Then it was the four of them, silent, the room quiet. Carla loved it, smiling so wide her eyes went to slits. Even Cody said nothing, crossing his arms and laughing to himself.

Cheyenne looked to Byron, her eyebrows never higher. She said, “Well, holy shit.”

CHAPTER 12

B yron had more questions but before he could ask them, Carla said they had to go back out to the deck so they weren't rude to Lily and Arlo. Byron said Lily and Arlo were still down in their room, and Carla said if Lily and Arlo came up they'd find no one around and that wasn't a nice thing to do. Byron had to agree. While the four of them were walking up the stairs to the next deck Byron got close to Cheyenne and said, "Why were *we* there?" Cheyenne said she didn't know, her mouth squirming around, brow lowered as she considered it.

They ran into Arlo and Lily in the kitchen. They'd changed clothes and looked rosy cheeked and happy. From the choices of fucking or fighting, Byron would bet Lily and Arlo were down in their room fucking, given the glow they both showed.

* * *

On their way down the stairs to the level below, Scarlet stopped them all. "Are we ready for this?"

Paloma lay her warm hand on the center of Scarlet's back. "That's what we want to find out, wouldn't you say?"

Scarlet looked down at the deck. “I’m not *sure* if that’s what I want to find out.”

Sully took her arm. “We don’t have to do *anything* at all, Scarlet.”

She looked up at her husband, could see the concern on his face, the way his brow furrowed, the reluctant flatness in his eyes. He was scared. Scared, she figured, of Paloma. Scarlet looked to Paloma now, standing expectantly, her monster-dick husband acting as some sort of talent scout, finding two of their friends who would play their games with them.

But were she and Sully the kind to play their games? It had seemed they were last night, the way it had all come together in such a supportive and amicable way. But what they aimed to do right now was as improbable as when she and Sully and Byron and Chey had tried to force it all happening. That had ended with disgruntled laughter.

Paloma came nearer to Scarlet, her posture slackened with concern, her brows tented. “I am too strong, yes?”

Philippe added, “Coming on too strong.”

Scarlet said, “You’ve always been so quiet, it’s— I don’t know, I guess it’s like I don’t really know you.”

“I think maybe that is more exciting,” Paloma said, cocking one eyebrow and smiling.

We didn’t know Philippe that well,” Sully said.

Paloma said, “You do now.”

Scarlet grimaced, then made reluctant eye contact with Paloma. What was it that scared her off this roost so bad? Was it because she’d been in charge

last night and now it didn't seem like she was in charge at all? That's what Sully would say if she'd had a chance to talk to him first.

Paloma's chin dipped down, and she lowered her gaze so it was even with Scarlet's, not above hers. Paloma was tall. That was part of it, too. It was hard for Scarlet to deny she liked being taller than other women, prettier, more dominant. Did Paloma intimidate her? She was tall and beautiful, tanned and exotic in her Brazilian manner.

Paloma laid a hand on Scarlet's shoulder. "I know what you need."

"You do?"

Paloma said, "Foreplay— no, *um momento*... Not foreplay, uh, it's... it's..."

Philippe caressed her slender shoulders. Paloma snapped her fingers. "Seduction! Seduction, yes?" She looked up at Philippe for the praise she figured she deserved. Philippe chuckled, dark eyes sparkling in the nighttime light.

"Seduction is the perfect word."

Paloma showed a sultry gaze to Sully and Scarlet. "You need to be *seduced*."

"I don't know about *that*," Sully muttered, rubbing an arm.

Paloma said, "Who doesn't like to be seduced?"

"So, what," Sully said, retreating to his sense of humor, "you're going to take us out to dinner, hold our chairs out for us, pay for the meal?"

"We just ate," Paloma said, frowning.

Philippe said, "He means how will we seduce them?"

“Ah,” Paloma said now, nodding, eyes narrowing. “We will find out what you like, make you like us, make you trust us.”

“*Earn* your trust,” Philippe said, and Paloma agreed with his clarification.

Sully got Scarlet’s attention, and she faced him. He said, “What do you think? It was good last night...”

“Well, that’s another thing: I’m not sure I’m ready for another round just yet.”

Paloma cocked her head and Sully said, “She’s still recuperating.”

Scarlet let her hand drift down to her tummy, just below her belly button, feeling weird doing it, but wanting to explain better for Paloma without having to say it.

“Oh, I see, I see,” Paloma said, nodding and smiling. Then: “I take good care of you.”

Now Paloma slunk arms around Scarlet’s shoulders and got close to her, embracing, smelling of musky talc perfume, her soft skin sliding on Scarlet’s soft skin arousing a strange case of the goosebumps. She whispered in Scarlet’s ear, “And maybe you relax, you drink, you watch me and Sully, we show you, entertain you... What do you think?”

And there was another thing that intimidated her about the whole prospect: the idea of Sullivan and Paloma together stirred up some jealous syrup from the bottom of her bowl. But that was an awful way to be, a way she should rise above.

Paloma reached behind her and hooked a toned arm around Philippe’s beefy arm. “Maybe the three of us entertain you. We put on a show, or . . . maybe we bathe your body with our tongues...” She showed a devilish smile that got Scarlet’s eyebrows raising high.

Now she felt the arousal that had been missing. Her heart picked up its pace and thundered beyond the heavy weight of dread that burdened it. A path clarified before her and she could see herself letting go, exploring more, doing more of what she did last night and going even further. Paloma and Philippe were beautiful people. Confident, comforting, and eager to have her. One thing she hadn't yet done was tempt her own fears of surrender. The idea this couple would take control excited the hell out of her. She didn't have the gusto to dominate Paloma. At least she didn't think so. She would have thought Carla would be a more intimidating partner, but that probably wasn't right. She would butt heads with Carla and she wouldn't back off. Between her and Carla she would think she deserved the control, or that maybe Carla didn't deserve it more than her. But with Paloma?

She said, "Let's go to the hot tub."

* * *

Group sex in a hot tub was cliched as fuck, but here they were. Here they were and he was excited as all get out. First thing he couldn't wait for: seeing Paloma naked.

The woman was drop dead gorgeous and sexy and smoky. And that accent? God damn.

When he pushed his shorts down, his cock sprang out and nodded up and down, stiff as a rail. He waited for Paloma to look over. He didn't have what her husband had, but it was pretty damn good and it worked well. When he looked to the side, Scarlet was still clothed, standing there texting.

"What are you doing?"

Scarlet kept texting, saying, "Talking to Chey."

“What for? To come down?”

Scarlet tucked her phone in her back pocket and shot him a look like he was stupid. “Tell her to stop anyone coming to the hot tub.” Then she looked down at his erection. “You think everyone is cool coming down, seeing you naked in a communal tub?”

Philippe said, “I think most everyone is fine with us getting in the tub naked, Scarlet.” He shoved down his shorts, his enormous dong half-inflated, down to the middle of his thighs, a large flesh club emerging from nest of thick pubic hair. Scarlet’s eyes went right to it, watching it squirm and dangle as Philippe stepped his muscular legs out of his shorts and stripped off his shirt. The look on his beloved’s blushing face didn’t annoy him; it bolstered his own excitement at the anticipation of seeing Paloma reveal her sexy body. He would ogle her as freely as his wife ogled Philippe. It seemed like they’d bypassed all those initial jealousy hangups and could exist now in a freer place where they were free to experience sexuality without harsh marital constraints; free to enjoy that wonderful riling of imminent sexual pleasure.

Scarlet answered in a robotic monotone, hypnotized by the swinging watch of Philippe’s huge organ. “Naked is one thing, but what if we’re... what if we’re...”

Sully stared at his wife’s mesmerized profile. “What if we’re what?”

When Scarlet didn’t answer, Philippe said, “*Ocupado?*”

Paloma chuckled a soft and sweet sound. “*Ocupado, sim. Muito ocupado.*”

Scarlet said, “Are we doing that here, ocupadoing?”

Now it was Sully’s turn for hypnosis, watching Paloma lift that light cotton dress, reveal her long tanned thighs, her pale yellow panties, her tight

stomach with a small jewel pierced in it. Then, good lord, bare breasts with tight dark brown nipples like Easter chocolates. She tossed the dress away and shook out her thick chestnut hair, metal bracelets singing, her ribs pressing her skin, her muscle rippling. In his periphery he was aware that Scarlet was studying him. A natural wave of shame passed through him, feeling disrespectful toward his wife just by *looking* at another beautiful woman. His eyes moved from Paloma's naked body toward Scarlet's unhappy expression.

She said, "*Is that what we're doing?*"

He smiled, seeing her look wasn't chastising him over ogling another woman—it was unsureness. His own guilt had tainted his perception. "We're not doing anything we don't want to, Scarlet. I'll follow your lead."

Scarlet smiled, her head cocking, her eyes warm. Maybe the first time in a long time he remembered having said the right thing in a situation.

Now his wife submitted to the moment and undressed in front of them all. Philippe watched, his freak show penis growing, extending, one ball going up, then down; it was like an entity in the group all on its own. Paloma's eyes danced over Scarlet's bare body as she removed all her clothing. When she was naked, it was Paloma who went to her first, catlike and purring, touching Scarlet's chest, her brown hand running up and down between Scarlet's breasts. Scarlet's eyes widened, and her nipples condensed to hard rubbery buds.

"Look at your body, you are so beautiful, oh my goodness. Your skin, it's so pale, so *perfeita*."

Scarlet sucked her lips into her mouth, unsure how to respond to the strong advances of a sexually aggressive woman so good at disarming her prey.

Paloma continued her grunted sounds of sexual rapture, caressing Scarlet's shoulders and arms, and stomach—but never touching the hot zones—admiring everything his wife had without crossing a line. Sully watched his wife's arm hairs raise and her nipples tighten even further.

Scarlet said, "You're, uh... you're so beautiful, too."

Paloma giggled and locked arms around Scarlet's waist, hugging her hard in the middle, forcing their tummy's together. Scarlet bowed back, her face retreating like she was reluctant, like she feared Paloma would kiss her with the great hunger that seemed to burn inside her.

Sully's eyes lowered to admire Paloma's tight round bottom in her yellow panties. Her skin was dark, her butt cheeks showing paleness where the underwear didn't cover. Her panty covered mound was mushed right against Scarlet's bare muff. His cock throbbed with his heartbeat, begging for action.

Paloma caressed Scarlet's blushing cheek. "This is not *a folia*."

"A what?"

Philippe said, "This isn't a fling."

Scarlet looked aside to Philippe, one foot on the step up to the hot tub, forearm on his thigh, big dick swinging. She said, "It's not?"

Paloma smiled, still gripping her arms around Scarlet's middle. "No, no, it's more. More, more, more."

Philippe clarified for Paloma. "Before we begin, I want you to know, *we* want you to know, we're doing this because we want a relationship."

CHAPTER 13

B yron put up a finger and told everyone at the table to wait, cocking his head and craning his neck to hear better.

Cody said, “What is it?”

“I heard it again,” Byron said, shaking his head, putting his elbows back on the table and fanning out his cards in front of his face.

“I don’t hear it,” Arlo said.

“A crinkling sound,” Byron said, and swore Arlo smirked. He said to Arlo, “Are *you* doing it?”

Arlo peeped over the top of his hand holding his own array of cards. “Doing what?”

“That crinkling sound.”

“*No*,” Arlo said, indignant.

“It’s like a plastic bag or something.”

Carla said to Cheyenne, “Does your husband have a paralytic fear of shopping bags or something?”

Cody chuckled. “Byron’s a *hardcore* environmentalist. If he finds a plastic bag on board this ship, man, look out.”

“Imagine if a plastic bag rustled up from the deck right now,” Carla said, laughing, “got caught in the breeze and wrapped right around Byron’s cute face...”

“And he’s running around screaming,” Cody said, cracking up, “trying to peel it off, cards going everywhere, then whoop, flips over the handrail—”

“Splash, right into the water,” Carla finished.

Byron stared at them over the top of his cards, Cody and Carla leaning against each other, trying to catch their breath, his eyebrows raised high and aloof, showing his measure of cool. “Well, whatever,” he said, “I heard it, you don’t, no big deal. But you know what’s a big deal?”

Carla wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist, sniffing. “What’s that?”

Byron popped his lips and tossed down the King of Hearts. “That’s a big deal right there, baby.” The card spun in place over the layer of already played cards in the center of the table.

Carla and Cody regarded it, more serious now. But Lily said, “Uh-oh.”

Byron peered around Arlo to look at Lily. “Uh-oh what?”

Lily wagged a finger across the table—and he swore he heard that crinkling sound again—aiming at Cody. “I think he’s got the—”

Cody flicked a card, spinning it like a frisbee. It floated down to break-dance on top of Byron’s King. “Ace of Spades, baby.”

“Fuck *you*, Cody,” Byron said, tossing his remaining hand down. He grabbed the hair at his temples, elbows on the table. “I thought it got played already.”

“That was the last hand, buddy,” Arlo said, patting Byron’s back.

Cody said, “This guy’s got plastic bags on the brain, can’t even pay attention.”

“You guys are probably doing it to mess up my game, break my concentration,” Byron grumbled.

“That’s five out of seven, B-Boy,” Carla said. “You know what that means...” She reached across the table and touched Byron’s wrist, and the feel of her skin against his sent electric waves of pleasure through his chest. He started back from his reverie, Carla still stroking his wrist. “What does it mean?”

“Do you want a truth or do you want a dare?”

“At this point, does it matter? What do *you* want?”

Carla’s touch retracted as she leaned back in her chair, eyes narrowed in sly contemplation. She looked to Cody as if he were her key adviser, but neither of them said anything, only smiled at each other and went through a range of comical expressions, moving their eyebrows up and down, twisting their mouths from one side to the other. Carla leaned forward, fingers interlaced like she was at the table for peace negotiations, eyeing only Byron, not Cheyenne—his teammate.

Byron scoffed, “Oh boy, here we go.” He flopped back in his chair and rolled his eyes.

Carla smiled, shifted away from him, and faced Cheyenne instead. “Cheyenne...”

Chey showed Byron a dirty look. “You didn’t remember there was an ace still out there?”

Byron threw up his hands in a what-are-you-gonna-do gesture.

Chey said to Carla, “All right. Let’s hear it. What have you got for me?”

“I want *you*,” Carla said, leveling a finger at Chey, “to take *him*.” Now the finger swept Byron’s way and his scalp prickled.

Chey said, “Take him, and...?”

Carla said, “Make him smooth.”

Chey frowned. “Make him *smooth*?”

Byron said, “What does that mean?”

Carla fanned a hand in his direction, saying, “Get rid of all that fluff. I don’t like it.”

“Fluff?”

Carla said, “The pubic hair, I want it gone.”

“I have fluffy pubic hair?”

“Scraggly, unkempt. I want Chey to make you bald down there.”

Byron chuckled and leaned back in his chair again. “You gotta be kidding me.” He looked aside to Arlo and Lily to see how they were taking such vulgarity. They looked unperturbed.

Carla addressed Cheyenne. “All gone, Chey. You get it? I mean the shaft, the beanbag, the whole kit and caboodle.”

Chey laughed into her hands for a moment, then moved them away. “Okay. The butthole, too?”

“No way,” Byron said.

Carla considered it a second and Byron repeated, “No *way*, Carla.”

“Yeah, you know what? The *butthole*, too, Chey. Good thinking.”

Byron gestured toward Chey, saying to Carla, “What about her? What about *her* pubic hair?”

“I don’t care about her pubic hair.”

Byron said, “What’s Chey’s dare? Why am I the one who has to get shaved?”

Lily giggled in the quiet moment after his question and they all looked to her, shocked she would involve herself. She said, “Well, she’s... she’s the one who has to do the shaving.”

Carla said, “That’s right, Lily, dear.”

Lily smiled, cheeks blushing, then covered her smile with a hand.

Carla said, “You know what else we should consider, you know, out of fairness...”

Chey looked suspicious, ready for trouble. “What? What else should we consider?”

“Three couples played. We won. Byron and Chey lost.”

“It’s true,” Arlo said. “We came in second.”

Carla dragged out the moment, smiling at them all like a sadistic Bond villain. Then: “Lily, I want you to go help Chey. Give her a hand.”

Lily gasped and covered her mouth with both hands this time. Byron’s eyes widened, staring across at Chey, who showed him a similar shocked expression.

Byron leaned forward, looking to Lily. “Oh, hey, wait... Don’t worry, Lily, you don’t have to do that.”

Lily turned to Arlo, eyes peeping over the tips of the fingers clasped to her cheeks and covering her mouth. The tip of her nose protruded, and it had taken on the same cute pink blush as her cheeks and chest. Her eyes showed fear and horror.

“Oh yes, Lily,” Carla said. “It’s time.”

Lily’s eyes stayed on her husband’s, her head beginning to shake no.

But Arlo sighed, tapping the edge of his cards on the table, like he was contemplating his wife’s fate; like he was in *charge* of it. The moment stretched on forever and Byron’s heart raced with dread and a strange excitement. At last, Arlo nodded, agreeing. He said, “Yeah.”

Lily shook her head no harder, hands still clasped to her face.

“Yes, Lily,” Arlo said. “Go with Cheyenne and give her a hand.”

Carla said, “There’s a lot to deal with down there. Maybe bring a brush cutter.”

In the moment that the others chuckled at Cara’s jibe, Lily opened her hands from her face and only Byron could see what she mouthed to her husband. He swore it was: “No, Daddy.”

* * *

Once they’d settled in the hot tub, Scarlet and Sully together facing Paloma and Philippe on the other, Scarlet broke the ice, saying, “The seduction began already, didn’t it? Before today.”

Philippe hooked a beefy arm over the crest of the tub, one arm going behind Paloma's head. "How so?"

Scarlet leveled her eyes on Philippe. "You seduced me."

Philippe smirked, cocking his head. "Wasn't it *you* who seduced *me*?"

Scarlet crossed her arms below the hot, bubbling water, sidling up to Sully. "You tempted me."

Philippe regarded Paloma, then looked back to Scarlet. "And *how* did I tempt you?"

Now she would have to admit it was the sight of Philippe's tremendous penis, which was a garish and embarrassing thing to admit. She didn't respond to his question, instead saying, "If Paloma had come first, and it was you who stayed behind, what would have happened to your plan then? How would you have expected me to react to Paloma seducing my husband?"

Paloma frowned like she didn't enjoy being a step behind, looking up to Philippe and speaking with him in Portuguese a moment. Then she said to Scarlet, "There is an art to seduction. Do you hate art?"

Sully laughed and elbowed Scarlet's side. "What would make you mad about that?"

"I feel manipulated."

"No, no, no, we don't manipulate you," Paloma said. "No, I swear it." She lay a hand over her heart, only the tips of her bronze fingers showing above the hot tub water.

"I'm especially hurt," Philippe said, though he smiled through it. "I thought our attraction was mutual, not a predatory event."

“That’s what Scarlet thinks, too,” Sully said, and gave her a funny look.

“Who’s side are you on?”

“The truth, baby, the truth,” Sully said, emphatic, widening his eyes at her.

“That’s what made it so fun. Don’t deny it.”

Scarlet lifted her hands above the water. “I just don’t get the whole thing about you planning this before we ever even got on the boat.”

Sully said, “Ship.”

Scarlet continued, “You know, like the whole point of this yacht vacation was to put the moves on us.”

Philippe shrugged, then Paloma imitated him, shrugging as well. Like they didn’t see the big deal.

Scarlet sighed and pinched the bridge of her nose. While she did, Paloma eased off the side of the tub, head and shoulders bobbing across the tub space, coming to sit on the other side of Sully, Sully smiling wide, eyes following along with her. Paloma and Sully eyed each other, and Scarlet said, “Like, what’s this about a farm and an opportunity? What’s all that? A relationship? What happened to just having fun, swinging, you know?”

“It doesn’t have to be anything,” Philippe said, gaze locked on hers. Paloma and Sully seemed sequestered now, checking each other out, Paloma batting big flirtatious eyes at him. Philippe nodded his black-bearded chin for Scarlet to come and join him on his side of the tub. Which she did, scooting across and turning around to settle in the space Paloma had just occupied, resting the back of her head on Philippe’s bicep. She looked up at him. “Am I being a wet blanket?”

“A little,” he said, eyes twinkling. “It’s okay. I get you.”

“Do you?”

“There’s no pressure, Scarlet. Relationship, no relationship, sex, no sex... Whatever you’re comfortable with. And it can change at any moment, and Paloma and I will respect your wishes.”

She whispered, “What about a *farm*? What the hell’s that?”

“Another time, Scarlet,” Philippe said in his low and masculine voice, hooking his arm around her neck and holding her close to cuddle against his side. He nodded his head now across the hot tub to Paloma and Sully, and Scarlet watched them.

The beat of her heart kicked up as she watched Paloma’s naked shoulder twitch and flex. Her hand was moving under the water, right between Sully’s legs. This beautiful woman was handling her husband’s cock, and by the heavenly look on Sully’s face—eyes narrowed, pupils rolled up, lips parted—Sully loved whatever Paloma was doing under the water. The spike in her heart rate, she deduced, was 90% excitement and only about 10% jealousy. This was fun. And another thing: the unknown was fun, too. Farms, relationships, polycules, opportunities, whatever the hell this whole thing was about—all that mattered was the heavy and lubricious lust that throbbed between her legs. Sure, her vagina ached from last night’s punishment, but somehow she knew these two (three, when you included her beloved Sully, best friend and husband) would consider her, take care of her. Satisfy her.

She cuddled harder against Philippe, quarter-turning into his warm, furry body, while she watched Paloma stare into Sully’s eyes and jerk him off under the water. Her own hand drifted across and into Philippe’s lap, searching for his mighty broadsword. She found it, heavy and half hard, hefting it up and handling it, happy to find him growing larger and larger.

AFTERWORD

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A man and a pregnant woman are shown in a close embrace. The woman, with long dark hair, is wearing a white short-sleeved shirt and blue jeans. She is looking up at the man, who is wearing a white shirt and blue jeans. His hands are resting on her hips. The background is a blurred indoor setting with light coming from a window.

Are you sitting
comfortably?
then I'll begin
satisfying your wife

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